GUESSS

Global University Entrepreneurial Spirit Students' Survey

GUESSS National Report CZECHIA 2025



STUDENT ENTREPRENEURSHIP

TECHNICAL UNIVERSITY OF LIBEREC

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Introduction

This report presents findings from the 2025 GUESSS (Global University Student Entrepreneurship Survey). First conducted in 2003, the survey is conducted approximately every two to three years and is one of the world's largest research initiatives on student entrepreneurship. The main objective of this international longitudinal study is to track students' interest in entrepreneurship, their career preferences regarding employment versus entrepreneurship, and the key factors shaping their entrepreneurial behaviour. The 2025 survey, coordinated globally by Swiss institutions, namely the University of St. Gallen and the University of Bern, collected data from 196,162 students across 66 countries.

The Global Report on Student Entrepreneurship Intentions 2025, published by Philipp Sieger et al. (2026), shows that young people are taking a strategic approach to their careers. Although the intention to start a business immediately after graduation has reached an all-time low, almost a third of students plan to start a business within five years of entering the labour market. Many decide to secure a job first to gain important experience before embarking on their own projects. The findings highlight that university ecosystems, study fields and individual characteristics – such as innovation capacity and risk tolerance – have a major impact on entrepreneurial ambitions. The analysis further confirms the persistent gender gap and suggests that student entrepreneurship rates are still significantly higher in developing countries than in developed economies. These findings are crucial for academic institutions and policymakers seeking to optimise study programmes, design business incubators and build inclusive start-up ecosystems.

In the Czech Republic, the Faculty of Economics of the Technical University of Liberec (EF TUL) has been acting as the national coordinator continuously since 2016. The Czech research team is led by the project guarantors Klára Antlová and Petra Rydvalová. As the national centre, EF TUL manages the full translation of the survey into Czech, defines local research parameters, coordinates data collection, and prepares the national report. The resulting data is used to strengthen academic research, improve university teaching and support student start-up initiatives, while participating universities receive feedback tailored to the specific requirements of their institutions.

Data collection for the 2025 cycle took place between September 15 and December 19 via an online questionnaire available in Czech and English. Students of all degrees and fields of study were invited to participate via official university communication channels, such as mass emails and internal information systems. The survey guaranteed respondents' complete anonymity. Valid responses were ultimately obtained from 1,387 students representing 11 universities across the Czech Republic.

From a methodological point of view, the survey relies on self-selection, which naturally attracts respondents with a pre-existing interest in or strong views on entrepreneurship. While this form of survey does not claim to be an absolute statistical representation of the entire student population, it provides an extremely efficient, rapid and cost-effective tool for mapping current student perspectives and generating sound scientific hypotheses. To facilitate international comparison, the questionnaire uses standardised global metrics, such as the EIQ scale for measuring entrepreneurial intentions and the IEO index for assessing individual entrepreneurial orientation. The collected findings are divided into five parts in the national report: chapters 1 to 3 assess the entire sample of Czech students; chapter 4 focuses on actively entrepreneurial students who are already running a business; and chapter 5 analyses aspiring entrepreneurs who are planning or starting their own business during their studies.

1. Demographic Information about the Sample

The first chapter defines the distribution of respondents by age, gender, nationality, and field of study. First, the data for the global GUESSS 2025 survey are briefly recalled (Sieger, et al., 2026), followed by data for the Czech Republic. The following data on respondents are addressed:

- Year of birth (age), gender, nationality (average/distribution)
- Study-related information (field and level of studies, university, length and intensity of work experience)

1.1. Demographic Information about the Sample – Global Comparison

The current GUESSS 2025 cycle represents one of the world's largest research initiatives on student entrepreneurship. The total global sample includes 196,162 students from 66 countries. This scale allows us to identify key differences between developed and developing economies and to track long-term trends in young people's career preferences.

Demographic Profile of the Global Student

The average age of students in the global sample is 22.6 years with a standard deviation of 4.8.

The global distribution of respondents is 53.9% female, 44.8% male, and 1.3% non-binary or other. Although women predominate in the sample, the report highlights a persistent gender gap in active entrepreneurship, where men have a 3.3% higher participation rate than women.

The educational structure is strongly dominated by undergraduate students, who make up 77% of the sample, while master's students represent 15.2%.

1.2. Demographic Information about the Sample – Czech Republic

According to the latest data from the Czech Statistical Office (CZSO, 2026), a total of 335,062 students' study at Czech universities. There are currently 26 public, 2 state (the University of Defence and the Police Academy) and 42 private universities in the Czech Republic (CZSO, 2026). The number of university students in the Czech Republic has been steadily increasing slightly since 2019. This increase is mainly due to demographic developments, as younger cohorts are entering universities.

Table 1 presents data on the number of GUESSS respondents in the Czech Republic from 2016 to 2025. Public universities are participating in the survey. It can be stated that the number of universities participating in the survey remains approximately 40% (26 public universities in the Czech Republic). Since the survey began in 2016, the survey has been conducted at 7 to 12 of them, so 2025 with 11 is no exception. In terms of the development of the number of respondents, the situation is similar: the number is stable. The only exception was the so-called Covid year 2021, when students were at home and working online, which could also have affected the increased number of respondents.

Recruiting respondents for questionnaire surveys among students of Czech universities has become increasingly difficult in recent years. Students suffer from what is called "survey fatigue". Universities themselves have to collect semester evaluations of teaching, conduct internal surveys (e.g. satisfaction with catering, accommodation, IS), and students are constantly asked by their classmates to fill out questionnaires for bachelor's and diploma theses, etc.

Table 1: Involvement of respondents in the Czech Republic 2016 – 2025, Frequency

	GUESSS 2016	GUESSS 2018	GUESSS 2021	GUESSS 2023	GUESSS 2025
Number of respondents for the Czech Republic with complete answers	1,135	1,254	1,971	1,407	1,387
Number of universities involved	9	8	11	12	11

In the assessment year 2025, 1,387 students from 11 Czech universities (0.71% of the global sample) participated in the GUESSS survey. Table 2 presents the universities and the number of students participating from each.

In contrast to the global trend (where business science dominates), the most strongly represented field in the Czech Republic is engineering, including architecture (18.0%), followed by business science and management (16.5%) and computer science (11.0%; see Table 3). This structure reflects the strong technical tradition of the participating schools.

Table 2: Universities in the Czech Republic participating in the GUESSS survey

	Frequency	Percent	Cumulative Percent
University of West Bohemia in Pilsen	**539**	**38.86**	**38.86**
Brno University of Technology (BUT)	**376**	**27.11**	**65.97**
Technical University of Liberec (TUL)	**290**	**20.91**	**86.88**
Jan Evangelista Purkyne University (UJEP)	**121**	**8.72**	**95.60**
University of South Bohemia in Ceske Budejovice	22	1.59	97.19
University of Chemistry and Technology Prague	13	0.94	98.13
University of Hradec Kralove (UHK)	10	0.72	98.85
Other	5	0.36	99.21
Charles University (CUNI)	4	0.29	99.50
Czech University of Life Sciences Prague	3	0.22	99.71
Silesian University in Opava	2	0.14	99.86
VSB - Technical University of Ostrava	2	0.14	100.00

Table 3: Universities in the Czech Republic – The main field of study

	Frequency	Percent	Cumulative Percent
Engineering (incl. architecture)	249	18.0	18.0
Business administration / management	229	16.5	34.5
Other	189	13.6	48.1
Computer sciences	153	11.0	59.1
Humanities (e.g., cultural studies, linguistics)	118	8.5	67.6
Natural sciences (e.g., physics, chemistry, biology)	97	7.0	74.6
Human medicine / health sciences	75	5.4	80.0
Economics	74	5.3	85.4
Science of art (e.g., art, design, music)	67	4.8	90.2
Law	64	4.6	94.8
Social sciences (e.g., psychology, politics)	56	4.0	98.8
Mathematics	15	1.1	99.9
Total	1386	99.9	
Missing	1	0.1	100.0
Total	1387	100.0	

Table 4: Universities in the Czech Republic – The study level

	Frequency	Percent	Cumulative Percent
Undergraduate (Bachelor)	977	70.4	70.4
Graduate (Master)	342	24.7	95.1
PhD	68	4.9	100.0
Total	1387	100.0	

Table 5: Universities in the Czech Republic – The courses online

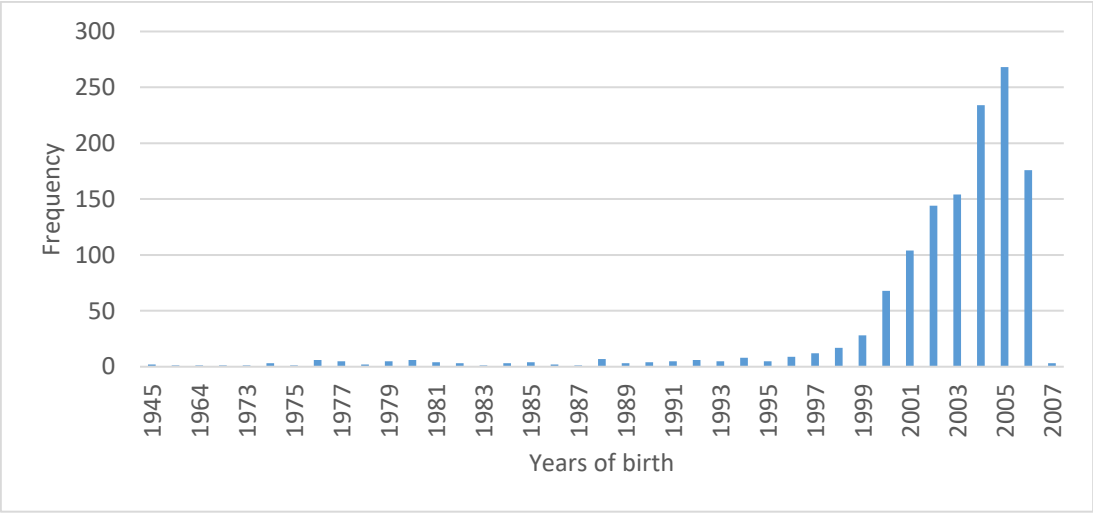
To what extent do you participate in your courses online/remotely (approximately)?	Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent
Less than 50 percent	946	68.2	68.6
50 percent	81	5.8	5.9
More than 50 percent	352	25.4	25.5
Total	1379	99.4	100.0
Missing	8	0.6	
Total	1387	100.0	

Table 4 shows that the Czech sample consists of 70.4% bachelor's degree holders and 24.7% master's degree holders. However, globally, the share of master's degree holders is significantly lower (only 15.2%). The Czech sample shows a higher share of students in subsequent levels of study, which may reflect a trend in the Czech Republic, where students are more often continuing to a master's degree than the OECD average.

In the Czech Republic, only 25.4% of students participate in online learning to an extent greater than 50%, while the majority (68.2%) use it to a minimal extent (Table 5).

Figure 1 shows the age structure of the Czech sample by year of birth. A total of 1,312 valid responses were used for this visualisation, with 75 respondents missing their year of birth. The graph shows a dominance of younger cohorts, with the largest number of students born between 2001 and 2005. This corresponds to the typical age of bachelor's and master's students (approximately 20–24 years old) and aligns with the global average age of GUESSS respondents, which is 22.6 years. The graph shows a "long tail" of cohorts born before 1995. This group likely includes students in combined study programmes and doctoral students, who together make up 4.9% of the Czech sample.

Figure 1: Years of respondents birth



Note to the graph: Valid/1312; Missing/75

This age profile defines the Czech sample as a generation that is currently preparing to enter the labour market, which is key for interpreting their career intentions in the following chapters.

Table 6: Gender of respondents

	Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Male	706	50.9	51.1	51.1
Female	650	46.9	47.0	98.1
Non-binary	16	1.2	1.2	99.3
Other	10	0.7	0.7	100.0
Total	1382	99.6	100.0	
Missing	5	0.4		
Total	1387	100.0		

The Czech sample is more balanced than the global one in 2025 – men make up 50.9% and women 46.9% (Table 6). This is a shift compared to 2023, when women predominated in the Czech Republic (56.7%), see Rydvalová, Antlová, Lamr (2024).

Table 7: Nationality of respondents

	Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Czechia	1208	87.1	90.2	90.2
Slovakia	82	5.9	6.1	96.3
Ukraine	22	1.6	1.6	98.0
Vietnam	2	0.1	0.1	98.1
Other	25	1.8	1.9	100.0
Total	1339	96.5	100.0	
Missing	48	3.5		
Total	1387	100.0		

The majority are Czech students (87.1%), followed by students from Slovakia (5.9%) and Ukraine (1.6%), see Table 7. The growing share of foreigners at Czech universities corresponds to the national demographic development.

The Czech Republic has fewer university graduates than the OECD average, but those who do earn a degree often have a higher level of education (master's degree) than is common abroad. If we take the entire productive population, the Czech Republic is one of the countries with the lowest proportion of people with completed tertiary (university or higher vocational) education (OECD, 2024).

The Czech Republic has approx. 27% of the adult population with a university degree in the OECD is the average, approx. 42% of the adult population. Within the European Union, the Czech Republic regularly ranks among the lowest (often the third lowest). The reason is the historical structure of the Czech education system, which traditionally relies on extremely strong secondary vocational education and vocational schools. There are 3 main factors of this situation (according OECD):

1. Strong secondary vocational education – In the Czech Republic, 25% more students study at vocational secondary schools (industrial schools, business academies) than the OECD average. The labour market has long been able to absorb these graduates without any problems.
2. High drop-out rate – According to reports from the European Union and OECD, more than a third of students (approx. 36%) who start a bachelor's degree in the Czech Republic do not complete their studies. Often, this is due to the need to earn money while studying or a poor field choice.
3. Financial barriers and background – Data show that the likelihood of graduating from university in the Czech Republic strongly depends on the education of parents. If at least one parent has a university degree, 60% of children complete their studies. If the parents do not have a university degree, the success rate of young people drops dramatically.

As Table 8 shows, Czech students are very active professionally already during their studies, compared to the global average. Only 20.6% of Czech respondents report having no relevant work experience (e.g., regular jobs or internships). This is in sharp contrast to the global average, where 42.4% of students have no work experience. Long-term experience: Almost half of the students (45.3%) have more than 2 years of work experience, with 17.2% of respondents having worked for more than 5 years. This data supports the "employee first, entrepreneur second" trend discussed in the previous sections. A rich work experience provides students with human and social capital that they can later use to start their own companies.

Table 8: Total length of work experience

	Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent
No relevant work experience	284	20.5	20.6
Up to 2 years	471	34.0	34.1
2-5 years	388	28.0	28.1
More than 5 years	237	17.1	17.2
Total	1380	99.5	100.0
System	7	0.5	
	1387	100.0	

The data further confirms that for a significant part of Czech students, work is an integral part of their student life. See Table 9. More than 60% of students in the Czech Republic currently work while studying (at least 1 hour per week), with the largest group (32.2%) working more than 10 hours per week. While 37.2% of students in the Czech Republic are currently not working, the global average is higher – 43.1% of students in the global sample do not have any job or internship in addition to their studies.

On the one hand, the high work commitment of Czech students may delay the start of their own business (due to a lack of time), but on the other hand, it reduces the fear of failure, because students already know how companies operate from the perspective of an employee.

Table 9: Current workload during studies

	Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent
0 hours	514	37.1	37.2
Up to 5 hours	192	13.8	13.9
5-10 hours	230	16.6	16.7
More than 10 hours	444	32.0	32.2
Total	1380	99.5	100.0
System	7	0.5	
	1387	100.0	

2. Career Choice Intentions and Entrepreneurial Intentions

The chapter focuses on the analysis of students' plans immediately after successful completion of their studies and 5 years after. It includes a comparison of a group of future employees, business founders, and successors in family businesses.

2.1. Career Choice – Global findings and confrontation with the Czech Republic

15.4% of students intend to start a business immediately after their studies, while this number increases to 28.3% 5 years after their studies. The share of students with the intention to start a business (5 years after their studies) reached a historical low in 2025 (down from 31.1% in 2018).

In the Czech Republic, 10.7% of students intend to start a business immediately after their studies, while 5 years after their studies, it is 28.8% (slightly above the global average).

The share of nascent entrepreneurs in the Czech Republic is 13.8% (vs 16.5% globally), and the share of active entrepreneurs is 3.4% (vs 6.4% globally).

Active entrepreneurs during their studies are defined as students who currently own and manage a business that has generated regular revenue in the last 3 months.

Nascent entrepreneurs are students currently building a business that does not yet generate regular revenue.

2.2. Career Choice – Detailed data for the Czech Republic

Table 10 provides a longitudinal view of students' career intentions in the Czech Republic compared to the global average (Across countries) over the period 2016 to 2025. The data follow students' plans at two time horizons: immediately after studies (Directly) and 5 years after graduation. Based on the analysis of this table and available sources, the following status of the **career path** can be stated.

1. The dominant pattern among Czech students remains a strategic approach to entrepreneurship, when starting one's own business is postponed until after gaining experience in employment. In 2025, 66% of students in the Czech Republic plan to enter employment immediately after school, while in a 5-year horizon this share decreases to 49%.

In contrast, the intention to start a company (Founder) almost triples over time - from an initial 11% to 29% after five years. This trend aligns with global findings, where the intention to start a business also nearly doubles between these two milestones (from 15.4% to 28.3%).

2. Looking at the most recent data for 2025, specificities of the Czech environment compared to the global environment can be identified.

In the Czech Republic, university students have lower starting ambitions but a stronger long-term outlook. Czech students are more cautious in their business plans immediately after their studies (11% of founders in the Czech Republic vs. 15% globally). However, in the five-year horizon, Czech students (29%) slightly outperform the global average (28%).

The Czech Republic shows a significantly higher share of students in the "Other / Don't know yet" category. Immediately after their studies, this is 22% (compared to 17% globally), and after 5 years, 20% remain undecided (compared to 14% globally).

In the Czech Republic, the intention to become a successor in a family or other company (Successor) is very weak, ranging only between 1-2%, while the global average is 3-4%.

Table 10: Career path

	GUESSS 2016				GUESSS 2018				GUESSS 2021				GUESSS 2023				GUESSS 2025			
	Directly		5 years later		Directly		5 years later		Directly		5 years later		Directly		5 years later		Directly		5 years later	
	Czech Republic	Across countries	Czech Republic	Across countries	Czech Republic	Across countries	Czech Republic	Across countries	Czech Republic	Across countries	Czech Republic	Across countries	Czech Republic	Across countries	Czech Republic	Across countries	Czech Republic	Across countries	Czech Republic	Across countries
Employee (%)	75	80	52	47	83	79	53	50	72	65	55	53	65	66	46	54	66	65	49	54
Founder (%)	6	9	28	38	6	9	31	35	9	18	26	32	11	16	30	30	11	15	29	28
Successor (%)	1	3	4	5	2	2	6	4	3	2	4	3	2	2	4	3	1	3	2	4
Other/Do not know yet (%)	18	8	16	10	9	10	10	11	16	15	15	13	22	16	20	13	22	17	20	14

The data from Table 10 confirm that Czech students perceive entrepreneurship as a real career path, but they approach it pragmatically. They prefer a secure start in employment, where they can accumulate the necessary resources and experience, before deciding to start their own business. The high share of undecided students in the Czech Republic (20% even after 5 years of study) suggests that universities have room to more actively build inclusive entrepreneurial ecosystems and support the transformation of these latent intentions into real activity.

2.2.1. Share of nascent and active entrepreneurs

Table 11 provides detailed data on current student entrepreneurial activity in the Czech Republic from the GUESSS 2025 survey. These data focus on two key groups: nascent entrepreneurs and active entrepreneurs.

Table 11: Share of new and active entrepreneurs - survey in the Czech Republic

	Frequency	Percent	Question
ACTIVE	47	3.4	Are you currently owning and managing a business that has generated regular sales over the last 3 months?
NASCENT	192	13.8	Are you currently in the process of creating an own business that has not generated regular sales yet?
TOTAL	1,387	100.0	

Based on the analysis of Table 11 and comparison with global data (Sieger et al., 2026), the following comment can be formulated:

1. Scope of entrepreneurial activity in the Czech Republic

Of the total sample of 1,387 Czech students, 17.2% (239 students) are involved in some form of entrepreneurship. The rest of the sample (82.8%) consists of so-called "non-entrepreneurs" who do not own a company or are not in the process of establishing one at the time of the survey.

2. Nascent Entrepreneurs

This group is the most numerous in the Czech sample. 192 students (13.8%) are involved in establishing their own companies that do not yet generate regular sales. In the Czech Republic, this share is lower than the global average of 16.5%. These students represent the market's potential. Globally, these "nascent" entrepreneurs most often target the sectors of the creative economy (Orange) or IT and digitalisation (Yellow).

3. Active Entrepreneurs

These are students, who are already running a real business and whose company has generated regular sales in the last 3 months.

Among the Czech respondents, 47 students (3.4%) are actively running a business. Here, the difference compared to the world is even more significant – globally, 6.4% of students are actively running a business. This low share of active entrepreneurs in the Czech Republic confirms the previously identified trend of "strategic postponement". Czech students embark on a full-fledged business with regular income less often during their studies than their colleagues abroad, and prefer the preparation phase (nascent phase).

The ratio between starting (13.8%) and active (3.4%) entrepreneurs in the Czech Republic suggests a significant predominance of the preparatory phase of entrepreneurship. Only about every fourth student who starts a business reaches the stage of generating regular sales during their studies. This "nascent-active gap" (the gap between start-ups and active operations) is deeper in the Czech Republic than the global average, which may indicate either greater caution among Czech students or a need for stronger support from university ecosystems to transform entrepreneurial ideas into real, functioning businesses.

2.2.2. Future career - economic sector

When analysing the sectoral structure of entrepreneurial intentions, the GUESSS 2025 international survey methodology uses a classification inspired by the modern economic sectors framework of the European Training Foundation (ETF, 2025).

The new approach to classifying economic sectors, introduced for 2025 by the European Training Foundation (ETF, 2025) in cooperation with the International Training Centre of the International Labour Organisation (ITCILO, 2024), moves away from traditional, purely numerical classifications (such as the European NACE classification). Instead, it introduces the so-called "Economy Colours". This concept arose because the boundaries between traditional sectors are blurred due to digitalisation and globalisation. The ETF framework helps visualise how sectors intersect and what new skills the labour market will require in the future. In total, the model defines seven coloured economies, covering specific sectors and trends.

For the purposes of empirical research GUESSS, and to maintain the level of data detail, this theoretical concept has been adapted into 10 specific categories. In addition to modern, transversal directions (e.g., the orange or yellow economy), this classification intentionally integrates traditional structural pillars (red and brown economies) and specific forms of entrepreneurship (social and rural

economies). Thanks to this hybrid approach, the research achieves comprehensive coverage of the global market and minimises methodological bias in students' self-classification.

Table 12 presents students' determination of their future career across 10 coloured sectors (ETF) according to their entrepreneurial status: whether they are already doing business during their studies (nascent, active) or not (non-entrepreneurs). The categories of this status can be defined as follows (the sample size (N) in each category is given in brackets):

a) Non-entrepreneurs – Students who do not engage in entrepreneurial activities during their studies (1,152 valid responses).
b) Nascent – Students who are currently in the process of building their own business during their studies and do not yet generate regular sales (187 valid responses).
c) Active – Students who currently own a business during their studies that has generated regular sales in the last 3 months (45 valid responses).

Table 12: Structure of career intentions of students in coloured sectors of the economy (ETF framework) according to their entrepreneurial status

	Non-entrepreneurs		**Active**		**Nascent**	
	Frequency	Valid Percent	Frequency	Valid Percent	Frequency	Valid Percent
Blue Economy (e.g., fisheries, marine tourism)	10	0.9	0	0.0	0	0.0
Brown Economy (e.g., non-renewable energy)	18	1.6	1	2.2	0	0.0
Green Economy (e.g., renewable energy)	77	6.7	1	2.2	1	0.5
Orange Economy (e.g., arts, music, fashion, design)	124	10.8	9	20.0	49	26.2
Red Economy (e.g., factories, construction)	185	16.1	6	13.3	24	12.8
Rural economy (e.g., agriculture)	15	1.3	0	0.0	5	2.7
Silver Economy (e.g., elderly care)	9	0.8	1	2.2	0	0.0
Social and solidarity economy (e.g., social welfare)	135	11.7	2	4.4	15	8.0
White Economy (e.g., pharmaceuticals, hospitals)	104	9.0	0	0.0	8	4.3
Yellow Economy (e.g., IT, AI, digitalization)	210	18.2	14	31.1	31	16.6
Other	265	23.0	11	24.4	54	28.9
Total	**1,152**	**100.0**	**45**	**100.0**	**187**	**100.0**
Missing/System	235		1,342		1,200	
	1,387		1,387		1,387	

The most striking trend in Table 12 is the massive inclination of student entrepreneurs (both active and starting) towards two sectors: the Yellow Economy (IT, AI, digitalisation) and the Orange Economy (art, music, fashion, design).

The Yellow Economy (IT/AI) dominates among active entrepreneurs (31.1%). Among nascent entrepreneurs, it is 16.6% and among non-entrepreneurs 18.2%. This shows that digitalisation and IT are sectors with low barriers to entry and high potential for generating real revenue during their studies.

The Orange Economy (Creative Industries) dominates among starting entrepreneurs (26.2%) and is very strong among active entrepreneurs (20.0%). This sector attracts students to start their own businesses (e.g., design brands, marketing agencies, artistic creation), though the transition to regular revenue may be more challenging.

The red economy (factories, construction, and industry) maintains a stable and relatively strong representation across all three groups: Non-entrepreneurs 16.1%; Active entrepreneurs 13.3%; Start-up entrepreneurs 12.8%. This sector offers a stable career choice, whether a student wants to start a business or be employed.

The Social and Solidarity Economy (e.g. social care) offer an interesting contrast. Among non-entrepreneurial students, it has a strong share of 11.7%. However, among active entrepreneurs, it drops to just 4.4%. This suggests that students oriented towards the social field are more likely to prefer an employment relationship (or the non-profit sector) to a purely commercial business with regular sales.

Some sectors almost do not attract students to entrepreneurship (dead zones). This can be due to either high capital requirements or the need for specific qualifications (e.g. medical). These are the zones: Blue, Brown, Silver and White Economy.

Limitations: Percentages for active entrepreneurs are very sensitive to small changes. For example, the 31.1% in the Yellow Economy represents only 14 students. On the contrary, the high number of "Missing/System" values for entrepreneurial categories indicates that the vast majority of respondents (non-entrepreneurs) did not fall into these two business categories at all, in line with the definition of the monitored group.

Students who are actively engaged in business or preparing to start a business during their studies are primarily focused on digital technologies (Yellow) and the creative industries (Orange), while traditional, highly regulated sectors (healthcare, social care) remain the domain of future employees.

2.3. Entrepreneurial Intention – Detailed data for the Czech Republic

(Entrepreneurial intentions, i.e., intention to start a new business)

The specific statements come from the internationally recognised Entrepreneurial Intention Questionnaire (EIQ), which was developed by Liñán and Chen (2009). This instrument measures entrepreneurial intention, which, according to the authors, is the best predictor of whether a person will start a business in the future. Liñán & Chen's (2009) publication is based on Ajzen's Theory of Planned Behaviour (1991). According to them, entrepreneurial interest is influenced by three factors: personal incentive (the attractiveness of entrepreneurship), social norms (peer pressure), and perceived behavioural control (confidence in one's own abilities).

Students responded to the six statements using a Likert scale, and the results are presented in Pareto charts (see Figures 2–7).

Figure 2: Entrepreneurial Intention – To be an entrepeneur

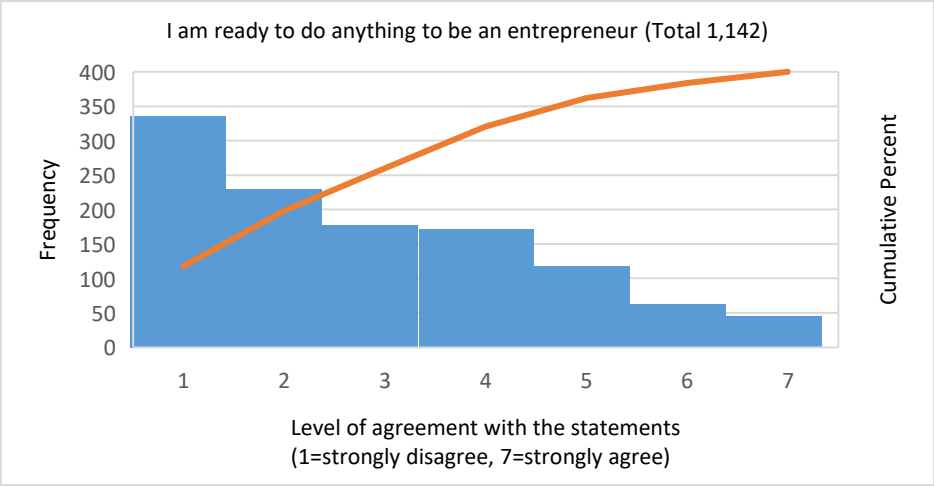


Figure 3: Entrepreneurial Intention – Professional goal

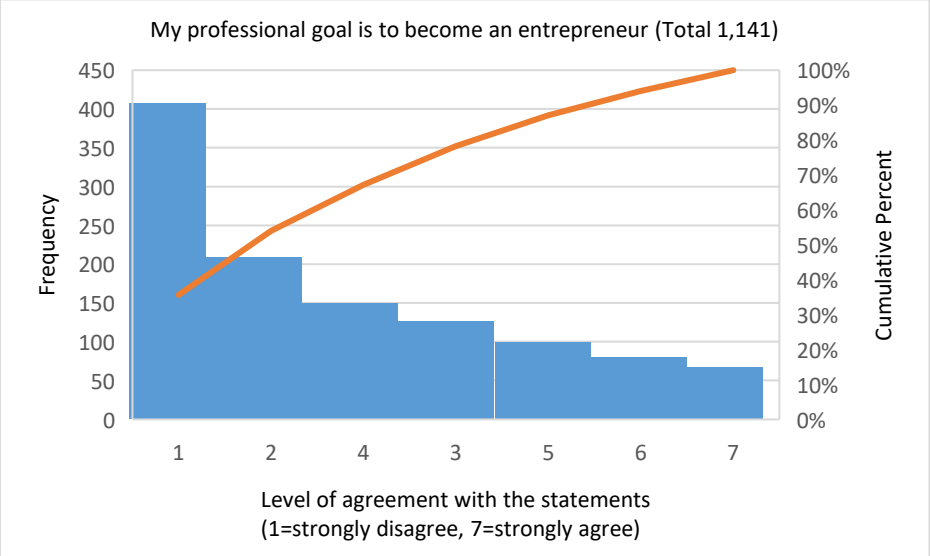


Figure 4: Entrepreneurial Intention – Start and run

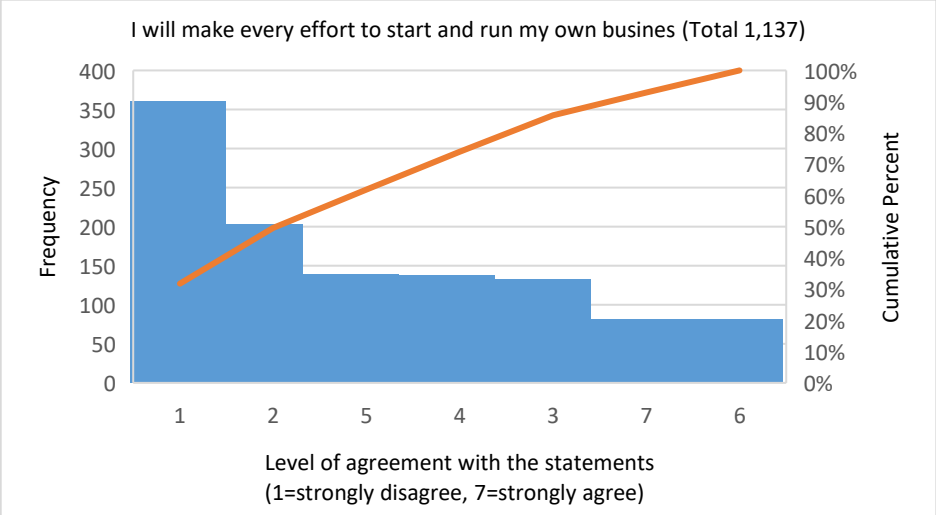


Figure 5: Entrepreneurial Intention – To create a business

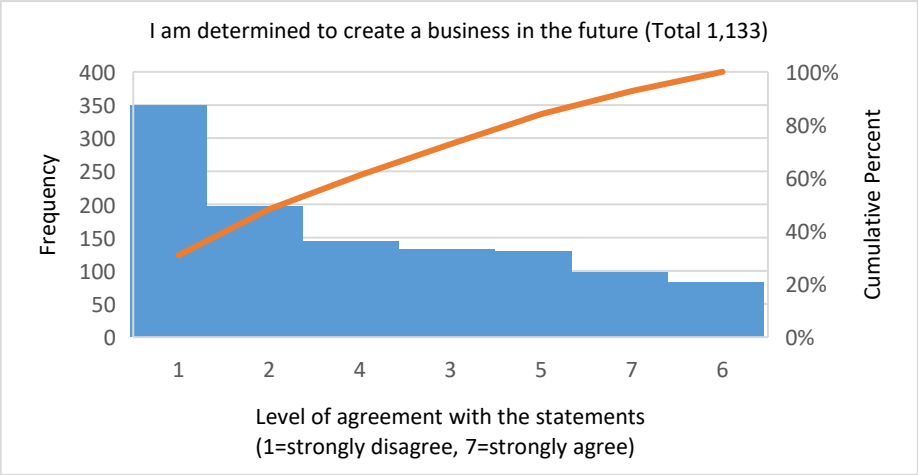


Figure 6: Entrepreneurial Intention – Thought of starting a business

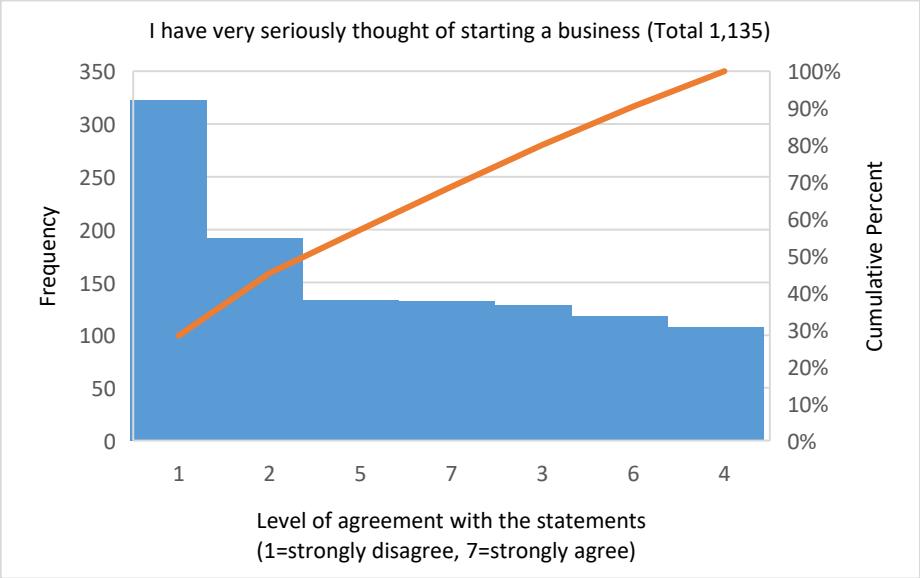
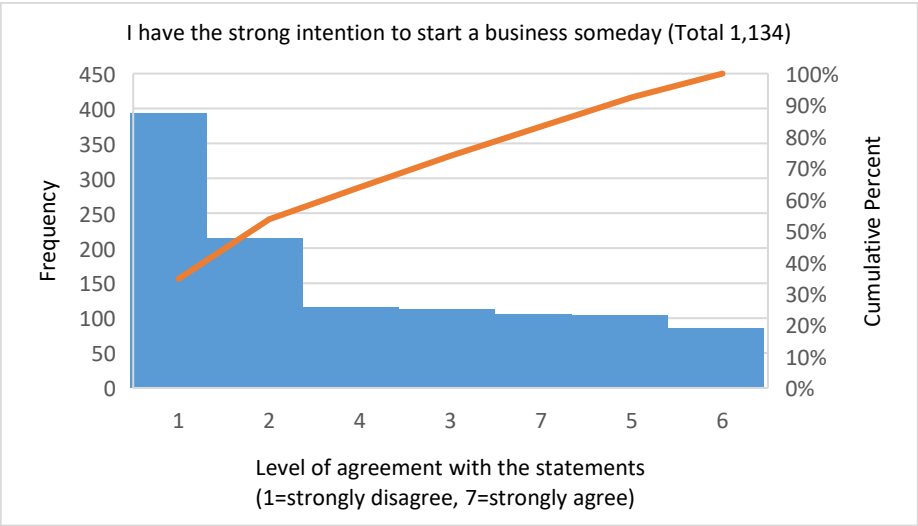


Figure 7: Entrepreneurial Intention – Someday



2.3.1. Entrepreneurial Intention – Evaluations

When evaluating all 6 graphs (Figures 2–7), a very similar and consistent pattern of respondent behaviour is evident. The distribution of responses is significantly right-skewed for all statements (low-agreement group). The following can be stated.

1. Dominance of low intention (Values 1 and 2)

For each graph, the largest share (columns with the highest frequency) is made up of answers 1 (completely disagree) and 2. The cumulative percentage (orange line) shows that, for most questions, approximately 50% to 60% of respondents are in values 1 and 2. This means that the majority of Czech students surveyed currently have no entrepreneurial ambitions, do not plan to pursue a career as an entrepreneur, and do not consider this topic a priority.

2. Stable middle (Values 3, 4, 5)

About 20-30% of students choose neutral or slightly strong answers. These people do not outright reject entrepreneurship, but are not clear about it, or consider it as one of the options in the future.

3. The reserved entrepreneurial core (Values 6 and 7)

At the opposite end of the spectrum (values 6 and 7 – I completely agree) is the smallest group of respondents. It is estimated that this is approximately 10-15% of the total sample (~1,140 students). This group includes students who are firmly determined to start a business, have a clear vision, and are highly internally motivated.

The following characteristics can be drawn from the survey of Czech students.

a) The high consistency in the answers, where the distribution of the graphs is almost identical for general wishes ("I have the strong intention...") and for more action-oriented statements ("I will make every effort..."), shows that the students answered very rationally and consciously. Those who do not want to do business do not want to make any effort.

b) Risk aversion or low entrepreneurial self-confidence (Perceived Behavioural Control), which is evident from the first graph, which shows the strongest disagreement ("I am ready to do anything to be an entrepreneur"). This suggests that Czech students are pragmatic. For them, entrepreneurship is not an "idol" they would sacrifice everything for. They value certainty, which corresponds to the socio-economic context of the Czech Republic, where the labour market is traditionally strong and employment in corporations or institutions offers a safer alternative.

c) Entrepreneurship as "maybe someday", not as an immediate goal, can be inferred by comparing the graphs "My professional goal is to become an entrepreneur" (where the value 1 is extremely high - about 400 respondents) with the graph, "I have the strong intention to start a business someday" (where the value 1 is slightly lower). It is evident that for some students, entrepreneurship is more acceptable in the horizon "someday in the future" (when they gain experience) than as an immediate career goal after school.

2.3.2. Entrepreneurial Intention – Connecting graphs with EIQ theory

The results of the EIQ questionnaire (Liñán & Chen, 2009) applied to a sample of approximately 1,140 Czech university students indicate a relatively low overall level of entrepreneurial intention. Most students strongly disagree with entrepreneurial plans. However, the research clearly identified a stable minority segment (approximately 10-15% of students) with a very strong entrepreneurial intention, which universities should focus on (e.g., through business incubators and specialised

courses). According to the authors' methodology (Liñán & Chen, 2009), these individuals have the highest probability of actually starting a company.

The connection of the graphs with the EIQ theory (Liñán & Chen, 2009) can be evaluated using the following three pillars.

Pillar A: Personal Attitude / Attractiveness of entrepreneurship (Personal Attitude) Connection with graphs: "My professional goal is to become an entrepreneur" and "I have very seriously thought of starting a business". The high frequency of answers 1 and 2 (strong disagreement) in these graphs indicates that entrepreneurship as a career path is not intrinsically attractive for most Czech students. They see it as high risk, stressful, or unstable, while employment gives them a sense of security and recognition.

Pillar B: Perceived Behavioural Control / Self-confidence (Perceived Behavioural Control) Connection with graphs: "I am ready to do anything to be an entrepreneur" and "I will make every effort to start and run my own business". Analysis: These graphs require "action" and determination to overcome obstacles. Massive disagreement (especially with the statement "ready to do anything") indicates low perceived self-confidence. Students either do not believe they have the necessary hard skills (taxes, legislation and management) or are unwilling to sacrifice their free time and security (high risk aversion).

Pillar C: Time horizon and peer pressure. Connection with graphs: Comparison of "My professional goal…" vs. "I have the strong intention to start a business someday". Analysis: A slight positive shift is evident here. While entrepreneurship is not the direct goal after school for most, the idea of starting a business "someday" is more acceptable to them. Students show a so-called latent (dormant) intention – they do not reject entrepreneurship across the board, but postpone it until they gain experience, capital and contacts.

2.3.3. Suggested solutions (How to change the situation?)

If the goal is to increase the number of entrepreneurial students at Czech universities, the solution must aim to transform the EIQ pillars described above (increasing attractiveness and self-confidence).

Solution I: Increasing perceived self-confidence (Hard & Soft Skills)

Introducing practical "Learn by Doing" courses. That is, instead of theoretical lectures on economic theories, it is necessary to introduce courses in which students, in teams, try to start a "dirty company" (e.g., using Lean Start-up methodologies and creating a Business Model Canvas). When they try the process in the safe environment of the school, their fear will disappear (Perceived Behavioural Control will increase).

The problem of Czech education is isolation. It is necessary to connect students from technical, IT, or art fields (who have a product/idea) with students from economic faculties (who know how to sell a product and prepare a business plan), and, i.e., interdisciplinary connections are needed.

Solution II: Changing personal attitudes and perceptions of social norms

Role Models (e.g., pulling), i.e., young, successful entrepreneurs, ideally graduates of a given university, should be regularly invited to classes. When students see someone, who was in their shoes a few years ago, entrepreneurship will no longer be an "unattainable dream for the chosen ones" for them, but a real alternative.

What is important is the destigmatisation of failure (Failure Culture). The fear of bankruptcy is huge in the Czech Republic. Universities should organise events such as "FuckUp Nights", where successful entrepreneurs talk about their failures. It will reduce the pressure of social norms and the fear that "if I don't succeed, I will become impossible".

Solution III: Support for latent intention (Working with the "someday" horizon)

The solution is to activate university incubators and accelerators. For those 10 to 15% of students who answered 6 and 7 in the graphs (strong intention), the school must offer support – mentoring, free consultations with lawyers/accountants, or a shared workspace (coworking) directly at the dormitories or faculty.

Given that many students only want to start a business "someday", universities should offer support in the area of entrepreneurship to their graduates (e.g. within 3 to 5 years of graduation), when these people have already gained experience from the corporate world and the time is ripe for them to start their own business. Alumni programmes can be offered, for example, through lifelong learning.

Summary of recommendations

The data from figures 2–7 clearly indicate that the barrier for Czech students is not an a priori resistance to entrepreneurship, but rather a lack of self-confidence and a tendency to postpone the intention to the future. The proposed solutions must therefore not only focus on theory, but also on institutional support (incubators), practical training (removing the fear of failure) and connecting disciplines, which are factors that demonstrably strengthen the entrepreneurial intention defined in the Liñán & Chen (2009) model."

The entrepreneurial intentions of Czech students in 2025 can be characterised as strategically postponed. While only 10.7% of respondents plan to start their own company immediately after graduation, this share almost triples to 28.8% within five years, which is slightly higher than the global average (28.3%). The research shows the dominance of the so-called "wait-and-see" approach, when students prefer to first gain experience and resources in an employment relationship. Although low or neutral intentions prevail among the majority of students (50–60%) in the survey, there is a stable entrepreneurial core (10–15%) in the Czech Republic with very strong internal motivation and determination, which represents a key potential for the development of university incubators and the start-up ecosystem.

3. Factors Influencing Entrepreneurial Intentions

This chapter analyses the key determinants (so-called **drivers of entrepreneurial intentions**) that shape students' entrepreneurial thinking in the Czech Republic and explain their decision between a career as an employee and as a company founder. The analysis is based on the internationally recognised Entrepreneurial Intention Questionnaire (EIQ), which is based on the Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB). According to this model, entrepreneurial intentions are influenced by factors such as the personal attractiveness of entrepreneurship, perceived social norms, and perceived behavioural control (self-confidence in one's own abilities; see Chapter 2).

This chapter aims to identify barriers in the Czech ecosystem and to suggest ways to transform students' theoretical assumptions into concrete entrepreneurial activities effectively.

3.1. Factors Influencing Entrepreneurial Intentions – Global findings and confrontation with the Czech Republic

Several key drivers influence whether a student considers a business career:

a) University Context

Globally, the university environment is rated 4.13 (on a scale of 1-7) regarding the atmosphere for entrepreneurship. The Czech Republic, with a rating of 4.1, is slightly below this global mean, suggesting a need for more inspiring environments.

b) Gender Gap

The gender gap among active entrepreneurs in CZ is 2.7% (in favour of men), which is narrower and more favourable than the global average gap of 3.3%.

c) Family Background

In the Czech Republic, 25.6% of students come from a family business background (where at least one parent is a business owner). It is significantly lower than the global average of 38.3%, indicating that fewer Czech students have direct entrepreneurial role models in their families compared to the global sample.

d) Individual Entrepreneurial Orientation (IEO)

i. Global Average: The global average for the IEO index across countries is 4.7.
ii. Czech Republic: The IEO index for Czech students is 4.04. In contrast to the global mean, Czech students score lower in key dimensions: proactiveness (3.99), innovativeness (4.05), and significantly lower in their willingness to take risks (3.49).

3.2. Factors Influencing Entrepreneurial Intentions – Detailed data for the Czech Republic

As part of the Czech National Survey 2025, we focus on four fundamental areas that shape these intentions:

1. **University environment.** We examine the extent to which the atmosphere at Czech universities inspires students to develop their own ideas. In the Czech Republic, this climate is rated at 4.1 (on a scale of 1–7), which is slightly below the global average of 4.13. The results indicate the need to strengthen the practical component of education and develop university incubators.
2. **Social background and norms.** We analyse the influence of the broader social context, which in the Czech Republic is characterised by high risk aversion and a significant fear of failure. Social norms in our country still strongly emphasise the security of employment in corporations or institutions, leading students with strong potential to postpone entrepreneurship to the horizon of "sometime in the future".
3. **Family background.** Family remains a key source of inspiration, but only 25.6% of Czech students come from families where at least one parent is a business owner. It is significantly lower than the global average (38.3%), indicating that fewer Czech students have direct entrepreneurial role models in their family backgrounds compared to the global sample
4. **Individual entrepreneurial orientation (IEO).** This dimension measures the student's internal traits, including autonomy, innovativeness, proactivity, competitive aggressiveness, and willingness to take risks. Czech students achieve a composite index value of 4.04. While this reflects solid internal potential, it is significantly below the global cross-country average of 4.7, placing the Czech Republic among developed economies with a more cautious, pragmatic approach to entrepreneurship.

3.2.1. Entrepreneurial environment at the university

The university's entrepreneurial environment (**university entrepreneurial ecosystem**) is assessed in two areas.

First, the University environment and climate are addressed (statements 1–3 are defined). The theoretical framework of Franke & Lüthje (2004) – Perceived University Environment was used to define them. Franke and Lüthje (2004) argue that perceptions of the university environment (support vs barriers) directly and fundamentally influence whether students even begin to think about entrepreneurship. If the university creates a positive climate, it functions as an accelerator of entrepreneurial intentions. As part of the GUESSS research, the following statements were presented to respondents:

- Statement 1: The atmosphere inspires me to develop entrepreneurial ideas
- Statement 2: There is a favourable climate at the university for becoming an entrepreneur
- Statement 3: The university supports students in engaging in entrepreneurial activities

The second area is education and practical support (Statement 4). The underlying theoretical framework used was Wang et al. (2022) – Entrepreneurship Education and Guidance. Wang et al. (2022) focus their research on tangible components of university support – the availability of advice, mentoring and formal education in the field of entrepreneurship. They show that easy access to information reduces students' fear of failure and increases their entrepreneurial self-efficacy. Against this background, the GUESSS survey presented students with:

- Statement 4: At my university, students can easily get advice and guidance on entrepreneurship.

Table 13 measures students' perceptions of the university entrepreneurial ecosystem (UBEE). The research instrument combines two established theoretical frameworks that examine how the academic environment shapes students' entrepreneurial intentions. For clarity, responses on a 7-point Likert scale are aggregated into three blocks: disagree (grades 1–3), neutral (grade 4), and agree (grades 5–7).

1. University environment and climate (Statements 1–3)

Statement 1: The atmosphere inspires me to develop entrepreneurial ideas

Disagree (1–3) = 40.8% | Neutral (4) = 20.8% | Agree (5–7) = 37.9%

Comment: This statement received the lowest level of agreement from the first three. Although the university as an institution may function well, students lack intrinsic motivation and the "inspirational spark" – more than 40% of students do not perceive the atmosphere as inspiring. From Franke & Lüthje's perspective, there is untapped potential in the so-called soft factors (e.g., networking, meeting successful alumni-entrepreneurs) that can inspire.

Statement 2: The university has a favourable climate for becoming an entrepreneur

Disagree (1–3) = 34.4% | Neutral (4) = 22.9% | Agree (5–7) = 42.2%

Comment: Here, the scales tip towards a positive assessment (42.2%). Students, therefore, distinguish between their own lack of inspiration (Statement 1) and the institution's objective-setting – they acknowledge that the university generally offers an entrepreneurial climate. However, the most frequent individual answer is neutral (grade 4 = 22.9%), indicating that a large proportion of students do not actively perceive or use this climate.

Statement 3: The university supports students in engaging in entrepreneurial activities

Disagree (1–3 = 33.4% | Neutral (4) = 18.0% | Agree (5–7) = 47.5%

Comment: The best-rated statement in the entire table. Almost half of the students (47.5%) perceive that the university actively encourages them to be entrepreneurial (e.g., through competitions, incubators, and optional courses). Extreme agreement (level 7) reached a strong 13.9%.

Statement 4: At my university, students can easily obtain advice and guidance regarding entrepreneurship

Disagree (1–3) = 34.1% | Neutral (4) = 21.1% | Agree (5–7) = 43.1%

Comment: The results show a solid level of infrastructure. 43.1% of students know where to go for advice and perceive this process as easy. However, more than a third (34.1%) disagree with the statement.

Table 13: University entrepreneurial ecosystem.

(1=not at all, 7=very much)	1. The atmosphere at my university inspires me to develop ideas for new businesses (Percent)	2. There is a favorable climate for becoming an entrepreneur at my university (Percent)	3. My university encourages students to engage in entrepreneurial activities (Percent)	4. At my university, students can get entrepreneurship-related advice and guidance easily (Percent)
1	12.6	8.8	9.4	10.8
2	13.8	11.0	11.1	10.6
3	14.4	14.6	12.9	12.7
4	20.8	22.9	18.0	21.1
5	20.2	19.3	18.0	16.6
6	10.0	14.4	15.6	15.7
7	7.7	8.5	13.9	10.8
Total (answers)	99.6	99.4	99.0	98.3

(1=not at all, 7=very much)

In the context of Franke & Lüthje (2004), Universities in this area exhibit a classic structural paradox. They are very successful at the declarative and institutional levels – they actively support students (Statement 3), and the climate is perceived rather favourably (Statement 2). However, they often fail to transition from institutional support to the individual psychological level. That is, they fail to transform this setting into real inspiration for the creation of their own ideas among the wider student body (Statement 1). In the context of Wang et al.'s (2022) conclusions, this points to a common problem in university ecosystems: information asymmetry. Advice centres, business incubators, or mentors at the university probably exist (hence the high ratings among the informed part of students), but their promotion or visibility across faculties is insufficient, cutting off a third of students from practical help.

While previous Table 12 and Table 13 examined what students want to do (sectors) and how they perceive the university's climate. Table 14 shows the real level of their involvement in formal entrepreneurship education. In the context of modern pedagogy and economics (e.g. authors such as Alain Fayolle (2009), the concept of Entrepreneurship Education (EE) is followed.

The GUESSS research also seeks to determine whether the university has a real, tangible impact on students (through courses) or whether students' entrepreneurship is more of an innate trait or the result of external influences. For university management, this is feedback on whether entrepreneurship subjects are effectively distributed among students or remain confined to the bubble of specialised fields.

Table 14: Entrepreneurship education

	False	False	True	True
	Frequency	Percent	Frequency	Percent
I have not attended a course on entrepreneurship so far. - Please indicate which of the following applies to you (multiple answers possible).	331	23.9	1,056	76.1
I have attended at least one entrepreneurship course as elective. - Please indicate which of the following applies to you (multiple answers possible).	1,213	87.5	174	12.5
I have attended at least one entrepreneurship course as compulsory part of my studies. - Please indicate which of the following applies to you (multiple answers possible).	1,238	89.3	149	10.7
I am studying in a specific program on entrepreneurship. - Please indicate which of the following applies to you (multiple answers possible).	1,316	94.9	71	5.1
I chose to study at this university mainly because of its strong entrepreneurial reputation. - Please indicate which of the following applies to you (multiple answers possible).	1,350	97.3	37	2.7

Because students could choose multiple answers, the percentages add up to more than 100%. The data reveal a stark contrast between ambition and reality.

A full 76.1% of students (1,056 respondents) have never attended any entrepreneurship course. This can be described as a massive absence of formal education in entrepreneurship. This is the most important data in the entire table. It shows that for three-quarters of the student population, entrepreneurship is an academic "blank slate". If we combine this number with the previous table (where 40.8% of students stated that the university atmosphere does not inspire them to do business), we have a clear explanation. Students do not feel inspired because they have no contact with entrepreneurship education at all.

12.5% of students chose the course voluntarily as an elective, while 10.7% had it on their schedule as a mandatory one. The fact that voluntary enrolment in electives exceeds that in mandatory courses indicates a healthy, organic interest. There is a "hunger" among students for this type of know-how, driven by their own initiative rather than by being forced by the curriculum.

Only 5.1% of students study a business-oriented field directly, and only 2.7% chose the university because of its entrepreneurial reputation. This result confirms that the universities surveyed are not perceived as typical "entrepreneurship incubators" (such as some elite business schools). Students primarily come here to study scientific fields (e.g. engineering, humanities, IT), and entrepreneurship is a secondary consideration for them.

Universities are building relatively good institutional facilities and support, but these facilities actually reach only a very small group of students. A full 76.1% of students miss at least one entrepreneurship course. The result is that active entrepreneurs are a complete minority at university, and those already doing business flee to low-cost, digital sectors (Yellow/Orange

economy), where they do not need complex university infrastructure but can manage with a computer and the internet.

3.2.2. Social and family background and norms.

Entrepreneurship is not an isolated process; it is deeply rooted in social ties (Social Embeddedness Theory). The presence of entrepreneurs in a student's network fulfils three essential functions:

a) Increasing entrepreneurial self-efficacy, where, according to Bandura's social learning theory (1997), the principle "if my friend or classmate did it, I can do it too" works. This reduces the psychological barrier and fear of failure.

b) Access to hidden resources (Social Capital), because entrepreneurial friends, mentors or relatives represent a shortcut to information, know-how, potential investments, suppliers or first customers.

c) Validation and feedback, which is critically important for active and budding entrepreneurs. They need a network of people who understand their problems. People outside the entrepreneurial environment often fail to understand the specific challenges of starting a business.

Students were asked whether anyone in their circle (other than their parents) currently owns and manages a business or is self-employed (they were given the option to select multiple answers). This question assesses the presence of entrepreneurial role models in students' social networks. See *Table 15*.

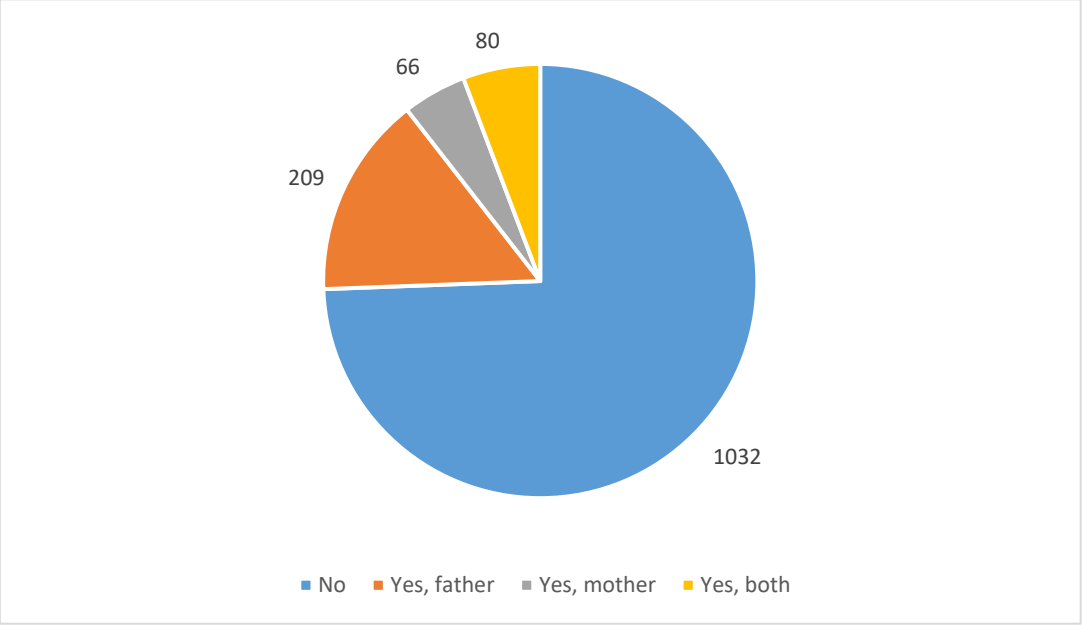
Table 15: Entrepreneurs in the social network of students in the Czech Republic

	Frequency	**Percent**
No	916	66.0
Yes	471	34
Total	1387	100.0
Yes (multiple responses possible, Total=471)	*Frequency*	*Percent*
Yes, siblings / other relatives	399	84.7
Yes, friends	461	97.9
Yes, peers (colleagues / classmates)	291	61.8
Yes, university professors / lecturers / mentors	211	44.8
Yes, other people who are important to me	315	66.9

The remaining third of students (33.8%) who have entrepreneurs in their circle draw inspiration primarily from informal horizontal connections. The strongest node is friends and acquaintances (71.2%), followed by other relatives (44.5%) and classmates (24.1%). These young people, who are close to the world of business, move in communities of their peers and extended family, where entrepreneurship is common practice. Within the third of students who have contact with entrepreneurs, formal institutional ties are the weakest. Entrepreneurial mentors and advisors make up 13.1% of the network. The least represented group is university employees and professors (7.3%). Academia and teachers thus serve as a direct source of entrepreneurial role models for students only very rarely.

The pie chart in the picture shows the distribution of answers to the question of whether the respondents' parents own a business or are self-employed. Of the 1,387 respondents, 355 students (approximately 25.6%) come from families where at least one parent is a business owner. Specifically, 209 students have a father running a business, 66 have a mother, and in 80 cases, both parents. This group can be interpreted as having an entrepreneurial core and a background. Although this value in this particular document is lower than the previously reported global average (38.3%), it still represents a quarter of the sample that has direct contact with entrepreneurial reality. Students with an entrepreneurial background in the family generally exhibit higher entrepreneurial intentions because they perceive entrepreneurship as a natural career path.

Figure 8: Entrepreneurial background in the family (Frequency)



3.2.3. Individual entrepreneurial orientation

The subchapter evaluates data from the GUESSS 2025 survey for the Czech Republic in accordance with the publication "Is it okay to study entrepreneurial orientation (EO) at the individual level? Yes!" by Clark, Pidduck, and Covin (2024). They argue that entrepreneurial orientation can be validly measured at the individual level through five dimensions: autonomy, innovativeness, competitive aggressiveness, proactivity, and risk-taking. The GUESSS 2025 questionnaire asked questions about individual-level entrepreneurial orientation (Clark et al., 2024). Students received the following instruction: Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements (1=strongly disagree, 7=strongly agree).

The methodology for calculating the IEO values for the research report was as follows. The calculation of indices for individual dimensions and overall entrepreneurial orientation is based on averaging responses to 16 questionnaire items, rated on a 7-point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree).

The overall index of individual entrepreneurial orientation (IEO) is determined according to the methodology outlined in Clark et al. (2024), which calculates the weighted arithmetic mean of the individual items. Then, the simple arithmetic mean for each of the five dimensions. The overall index of individual entrepreneurial orientation is determined as the average of all 16 indicators (questions).

The average value of the overall IEO index **for Czech students** is 4.04 (on a scale of 1–7), which is consistent with the global average in the GUESSS 2025 survey. However, when looking at the individual dimensions (calculated from the frequencies of responses), we see significant differences:

1. Autonomy (4.63) - This dimension achieves the highest rating. Czech students show a strong need for independence and a perceived ability to control their future.

2. Competitive aggression (4.05) - This area reflects students' willingness to face rivals and respond to competitive challenges. Most responses concentrate around the middle of the scale.

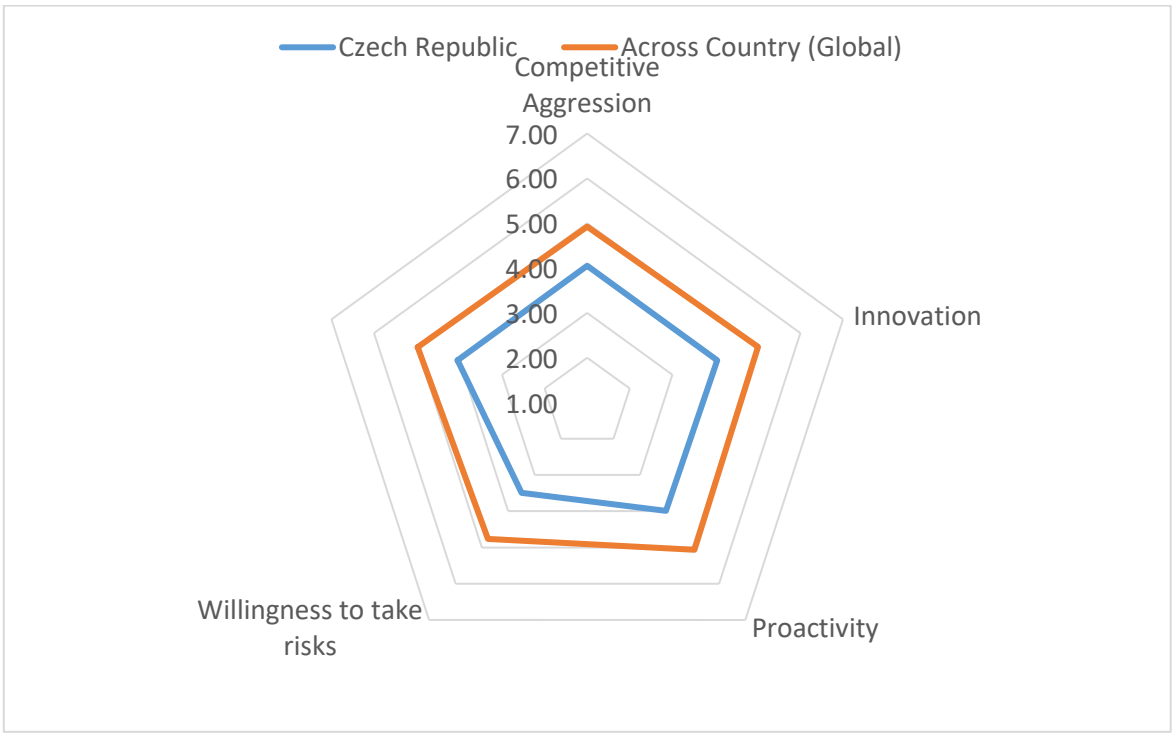
3. Innovativeness (4.05) - Students are just above neutral. They show higher scores in the general perception of themselves as innovators than in the specific experimentation with new procedures.

4. Proactivity (3.99) - The average value indicates a slight reserve in anticipating future opportunities and acting ahead of others.

5. Willingness to take risks (3.49) - This dimension is rated the lowest. The result confirms the previously identified trend of high-risk aversion and fear of failure among Czech students.

The results of the evaluation of all five dimensions, along with a comparison with the average for all countries, are shown in Figure 9. Following the findings of the global GUESSS 2025 survey report, which presents the Individual Entrepreneurial Orientation (IEO) index across countries, the Czech Republic's position is further addressed.

Figure 9: IEO – Czech Republic and across countries



Note: 1=strongly disagree, 7=strongly agree

3.2.4. The Czech Republic and the Global Paradox: Developing vs. Developed Countries

As presented in the global GUESSS report by Sieger et al. (2026, Figure 21), a stable pattern can be identified, which the authors describe as a trend: developing countries show significantly higher values of entrepreneurial orientation than developed countries.

At the top of the ranking of countries with the highest IEO (average 5.4) are Tanzania, Mexico, Argentina, Panama and Guinea. In these economies, entrepreneurship is often perceived as a necessity (necessity entrepreneurship) or the primary path to social mobility and livelihood. This naturally increases the willingness of students to take risks and act proactively.

At the opposite end of the spectrum of countries with the lowest IEO (average 4.0–4.1) are Norway, Austria, Japan and the Czech Republic. These countries share high living standards, strong social security and a stable labour market, where employment in large corporations or the state sector represents a safe and attractive alternative to entrepreneurial risk.

In a global comparison, the Czech Republic scores 4.1 on the IEO, which is significantly below the global average of 4.7.

The Czech Republic's position is almost identical to Japan (4.1), Austria (4.0) and Norway (4.0). This suggests that Czech students think very similarly to students in the world's most advanced economies – they perceive entrepreneurship more as an option that can be strategically postponed until after gaining experience, rather than as an immediate necessity for survival.

The Czech IEO average (calculated by a weighted average of 4.04) is most negatively affected by the low willingness to take risks (3.49). It is in this dimension that the largest gap between the Czech Republic and the top-ranked countries is, where the level of risk acceptance is disproportionately higher.

To illustrate the breadth of the entrepreneurial spirit among students, the following extremes can be cited (see Table 16).

Table 16: IEO – Examples of opposites

Country	**IEO Value**	**Context (according to GUESSS reports)**
Tanzania (TZA)	5.4	Extremely strong entrepreneurship driven by ambition and a lack of other career paths.
Mexico (MEX)	5.4	Culture with a high emphasis on proactivity and personal initiative.
Czech Republic (CZE)	4.1	Pragmatic approach, preference for certainty and low risk aversion.
Norway (NOR)	4.0	Lowest measured value; strong welfare state reduces perceived need for entrepreneurship.

The Czech Republic's position at the bottom of the IEO score is not necessarily a signal of "un-entrepreneurialism" in the negative sense, but rather a manifestation of economic maturity and stability. Students in the Czech Republic feel autonomous (they achieve above-average values in the autonomy dimension). Still, their entrepreneurial intentions are hampered by a low willingness to take unnecessary risks, a trait typical of safe, wealthy societies.

The analysis of the identified barriers, in particular high-risk aversion and insufficient practical inspiration in the university environment, emphasises and confirms the necessity of implementing targeted measures in the form of practical teaching and mentoring, which are elaborated in more detail in Chapter 2.3.3. It is precisely the connection of strong institutional support with the development of individual student self-confidence that represents a key mechanism for overcoming the deep 'nascent-active' gap and effectively transforming latent intentions into real entrepreneurial activities.

4. Active Entrepreneurs

This chapter provides a more detailed look at students who already own and operate a business. The survey focuses on assessing their performance and their fear of failure. These characteristics come from research by Cacciotti, Hayton, Mitchell, and Allen (2020). The authors explain how subjective threat assessments influence a firm's strategic orientation, particularly in the areas of innovation and risk-taking.

4.1. Active Entrepreneurs – Global findings and confrontation with the Czech Republic

The low number of active Czech entrepreneurs (Table 17) is probably related to the fact that students are extremely active in the labour market already during their studies. Only 20.6% of them have no work experience, compared to 42.4% globally. Family background can also play an important role. 40.6% of Czech students come from families where at least one parent is a business owner, which is above the global average (38.3%) and forms a strong foundation for future initiatives. Czech students also do not start businesses out of existential necessity, as in developing countries, but they approach their own business carefully, often only after several years of experience in the field.

Table 17: Numbers of active entrepreneurs in the Czech Republic compared to the global average

	Frequency	Percent
ACTIVE (Czechia)	47	3.4
ACTIVE (Global)	11,783	6.4

It can be stated that globally 63.8% of active student entrepreneurs are first-time company founders. Both globally and in the Czech Republic, the fear of failure is rated as medium (on a scale between 4 and 5).

- Czech Republic: 4.35
- Global average: 4.61

Czech student entrepreneurs are somewhat more self-critical when it comes to assessing the performance of their company compared to the global average.

4.2. Active Entrepreneurs – Detailed data for the Czech Republic

Only 45 out of 47 active Czech entrepreneurs in the GUESSS survey answered detailed questions. In the case of 34 of them, this is their first business. Nine of the active entrepreneurs stated that they have been in business for 10 or more years (the participation of students in the combined form of study can be assumed here), 13 of them founded a business in 2024. The average period of business of the respondents is 5 years. 62% of them have a maximum of one employee.

76% of active entrepreneurs have an ownership stake of 51% or more in their company. 33% of them have partners, 22% have 1 partner, 4% have two partners, and 7% have three or more.

4.2.1. Behavior as an Entrepreneur

Next, we will focus on selected areas of "behaving like an entrepreneur", specifically on the topic of unethical organizational behaviour according to the methodological procedure of Umphress et al. (2010). The authors developed a six-item unidimensional scale (UPB Scale). Originally, seven items were created based on interviews with MBA students, after psychometric verification one item was eliminated and the resulting scale contains six items. Respondents rate their agreement with individual statements on a seven-point Likert scale 1 = strongly disagree; 7 = strongly agree. They commented on the following statements. "If it would help my company, I would...":

1. … misrepresent (distorted) the truth to make it look good.
2. … exaggerated the truth about its products or services from customers and clients.
3. … withheld negative information about it from customers and clients.
4. … gave a good recommendation on behalf of an incompetent employee in the hope that the person would become a problem for another company.
5. … withheld a refund from a customer or client who was mistakenly overcharged.
6. … withheld information from the public that could harm my company.

The total score is determined as the average or sum of all six items. A higher score indicates a higher willingness to commit unethical acts for the benefit of the organization, a higher level of acceptance of unethical behaviour motivated by the interests of the organization. Interpretation used:

1.0–2.9 – low tendency to unethical pro-organizational behaviour,

3.0–4.9 – medium tendency,

5.0–7.0 – high tendency.

Figure 10: Tendency of Czech respondents towards unethical pro-organizational behaviour

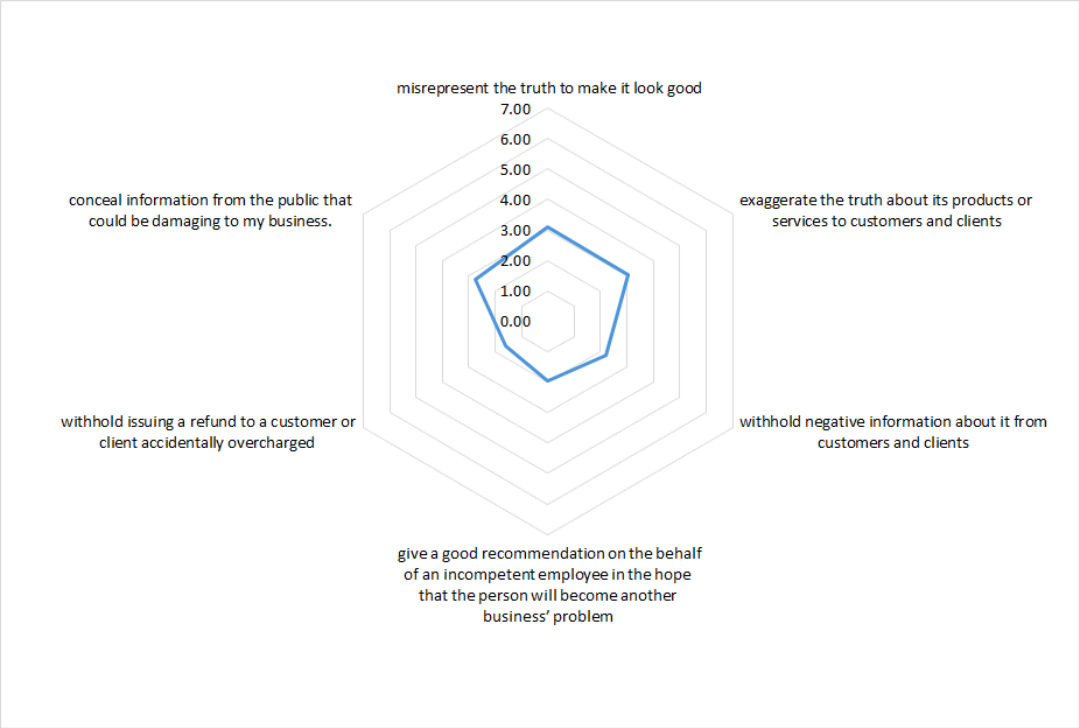


Figure 10 shows the average rating of individual items on the Unethical Pro-organizational Behaviour (UPB) scale according to Umphress et al. (2010), which measures the willingness to act unethically for the benefit of one's own organization. Overall, all items achieve values below the middle of the seven-point scale, which indicates that Czech respondents show a rather low to medium-low tendency towards unethical pro-organizational behaviour.

The highest levels of agreement were achieved by statements regarding distorting the truth in order to improve the company's image (approximately 3.0 points) and exaggerating the features of products or services towards customers (approximately 2.8 points). A relatively higher willingness was also recorded for the item of withholding information from the public that could harm the company (approximately 2.4 points). These results indicate that respondents are more willing to admit to actions related to the presentation of the organization or marketing communication than actions that have a direct impact on customers.

On the contrary, the lowest rating was given to the item of not returning an overpayment to a customer (approximately 0.9 points), followed by a recommendation from an incompetent employee (approximately 1.5 points). The item concerning concealing negative information from customers (approximately 2.0 points) also showed a low score. These results show that respondents reject in particular those forms of unethical behaviour that could directly harm customers or violate the basic principles of fair business conduct. The overall profile suggests that Czech respondents, although they admit to a limited extent certain forms of "pro-organizational loyalty", such as cosmetic distortion of information in favour of the company, strongly reject actions associated with direct harm to customers or employees. The results thus indicate a relatively low acceptance of unethical pro-organizational behaviour, with the highest willingness appearing for less serious or socially more commonly tolerated forms of information distortion, while more serious unethical practices are mostly rejected by respondents.

4.2.2. Fear of Failure: Globally and in Czechia

Furthermore, the "fear of failure" was assessed in active entrepreneurs (Cacciotti, Hayton, Mitchell and Allen, 2020). The study presents and validates a multidimensional scale for measuring fear of failure in active entrepreneurs, understanding fear as a temporary psychological state including both cognitive and emotional components. According to Cacciotti et al. (2020), the following levels can be defined:

1.0–2.9 – low level of entrepreneurial fear;

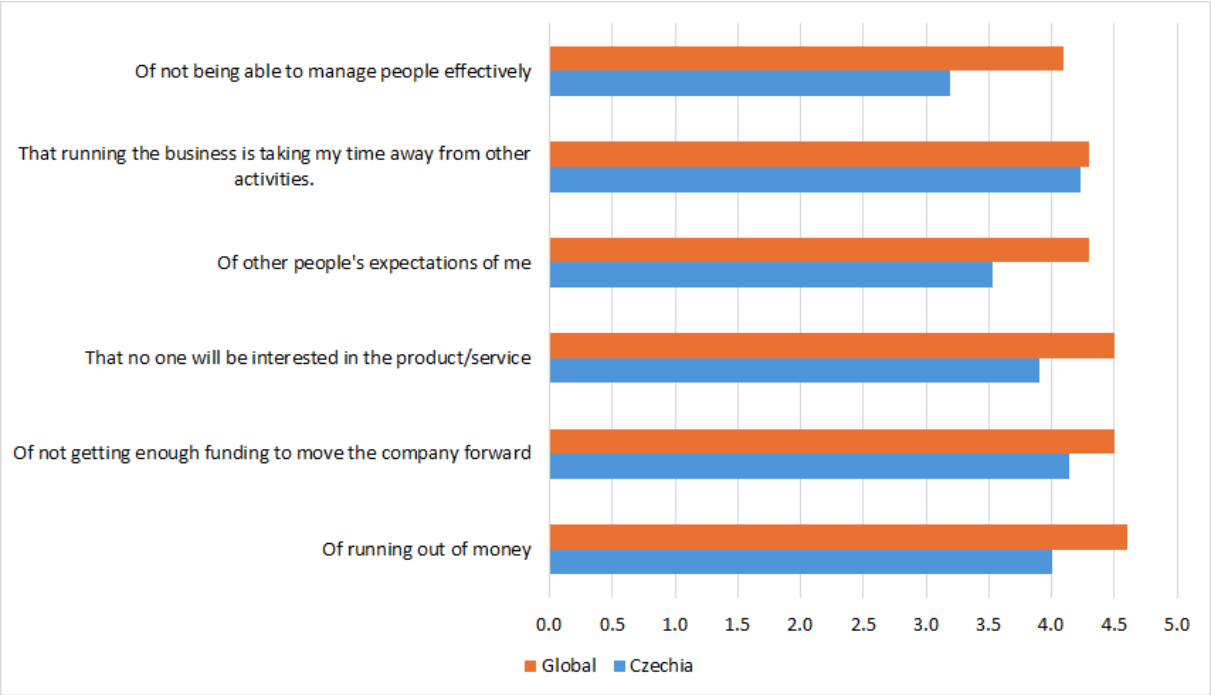
3.0–4.9 – medium level; fear is present but may not significantly limit entrepreneurial behaviours;

5.0–7.0 – high level; it is recommended to analyse in detail the specific sources of fear and their influence on decision-making.

These cut-off values represent only a distribution for interpretative recommendations. Respondents were asked to indicate the extent to which they had been afraid of several problems in the last few months (1 = not afraid at all, 7 = very afraid).

As shown in Figure 11, absolute levels in the Czech Republic range between 3.2 and 4.2, indicating a medium level of fear. These are slightly lower (better) results than in the global survey, where the rating was between 4.1 and 4.6, i.e. a medium level of fear.

Figure 11: Entrepreneurial fear of failure of active entrepreneurs (Globally and in Czechia)



4.2.3. Firm Performance (Self-assessment):

The company's performance was measured in relation to the findings of the study by Dess, G. G., & Robinson, R. B. Jr. (1984). The authors demonstrated that subjective performance assessment by top management is a suitable alternative where objective financial data is not available. This methodology is followed, for example, by Eddleston, K. A., Kellermanns, F. W., & Sarathy, R. (2008). The authors use subjective assessment of company performance by comparing it with its main competitors in several key business areas. This approach has become a standard, especially in research on small and medium-sized enterprises and family businesses. Based on this, respondents were asked how they rate the performance of their company compared to its competitors since its establishment in the following respects (1 = much worse, 7 = much better)?

- 1 Sales growth
- 2 Market share growth
- 3 Profit growth
- 4 Job creation
- 5 Innovativeness

The average score of all items is calculated for the evaluation. A higher score means a higher subjectively perceived company performance. Individual dimensions (e.g. sales growth or competitiveness) can also be analysed separately. The following distribution of levels of comparison of own performance against the competition can be used for interpretation.

1.0–2.9 – low performance compared to the competition.

3.0–4.9 – average performance.

5.0–7.0 – above-average to high company performance.

According to Sieger et al. (2026), the resulting performance for the respondents is estimated to be lower than the global average. The average subjectively assessed performance of Czech respondents reached a value of 4.35, which is lower than the global average of 4.61 reported by Sieger et al. (2026). The results thus indicate that Czech entrepreneurs perceive the performance of their companies as slightly lower compared to the international average. Nevertheless, the achieved value is in the range of average performance and does not indicate significantly below-average results.

Figure 12: Profile of subjectively perceived performance of Czech respondents' companies compared to their competitors

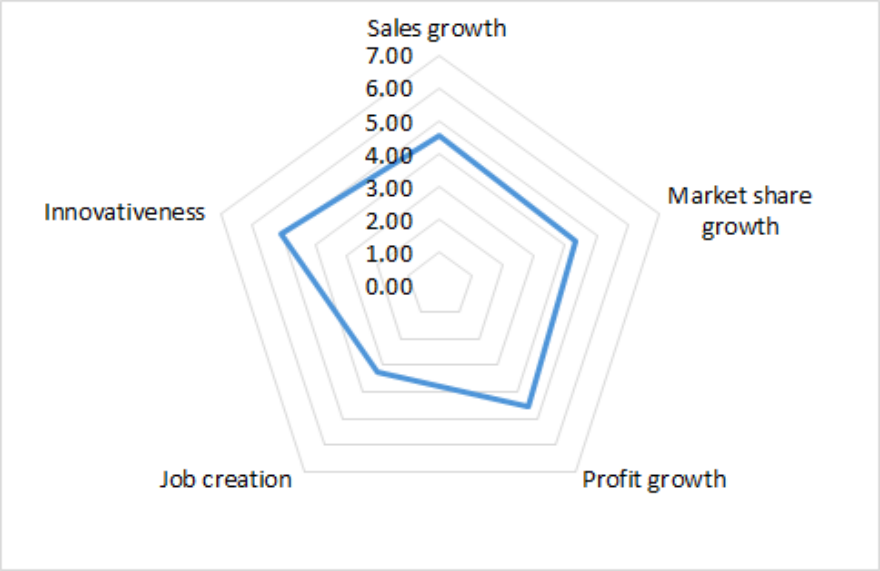


Figure 12 shows the subjective assessment of Czech ACTIVE respondents' company performance across all five dimensions. Respondents rated revenue growth most favourably, reaching approximately 4.6 points, indicating that companies perceive their growth as slightly better than that of their competitors. Innovativeness (approximately 4.5 points) and profit growth (around 4.2 points) also received relatively high ratings. These results show that respondents consider their companies to be relatively competitive, especially in the areas of business development and innovation.

Conversely, job creation received the lowest rating, reaching only approximately 2.4 points. This suggests that most companies did not expand their workforce at the same pace as their competitors during the evaluated period, or focused on growth through productivity gains, digitalization, or more efficient use of existing human resources instead of personnel expansion. Market share growth was also rated rather average (approximately 3.7 points), which may indicate that although companies achieve sales growth, this growth is not always associated with a significant strengthening of their competitive position in the market.

Overall, it can be stated that the performance profile of Czech respondents shows balanced results in the areas of economic performance and innovation, while employment expansion is the weakest area. This picture corresponds to the characteristics of many small and medium-sized enterprises, which strive for qualitative growth based on innovation, productivity and efficient use of resources rather than a large-scale increase in the number of employees. The limitation of presenting results for the Czech Republic is the low number of respondents.

5. Nascent Entrepreneurs

The fifth chapter deals with the characteristics of students in the process of starting a company, what activities they carry out for this (business plan, product development.

Nascent entrepreneurs are defined in the GUESSS survey as students who are in the process of starting their own business but are not yet generating regular sales. This group represents the market's future potential and is much more numerous in the Czech Republic than the group of students already in business.

5.1. Nascent Entrepreneurs – Global findings and confrontation with the Czech Republic

The group of nascent entrepreneurs—students currently in the process of founding a business that does not yet generate regular revenue—represents the primary reservoir of future market potential. In the Czech Republic, this group is significantly more numerous than active entrepreneurs, reflecting the market's potential, though its overall share remains slightly below the global average. While 16.5% of students worldwide are currently starting a business, in the Czech Republic, this figure stands at 13.8% (192 students).

Several key characteristics define this group in the Czech context:

The Nascent-Active Gap: A fundamental distinction between Czechia and the global sample lies in the depth of the transition from planning to actual operation. Globally, the gap is narrower, whereas in the Czech Republic, only one in four students in the nascent phase actually reaches the stage of generating regular sales during their studies. This suggests a pronounced "strategic postponement" or a higher degree of caution among Czech students compared to their international peers.

Business Planning Maturity: Despite the lower transition rate, Czech nascent entrepreneurs are as diligent in formal planning as their global counterparts. Approximately 43.4% of Czech students in this phase have already written a business plan, which is almost identical to the global average of 43.7%.

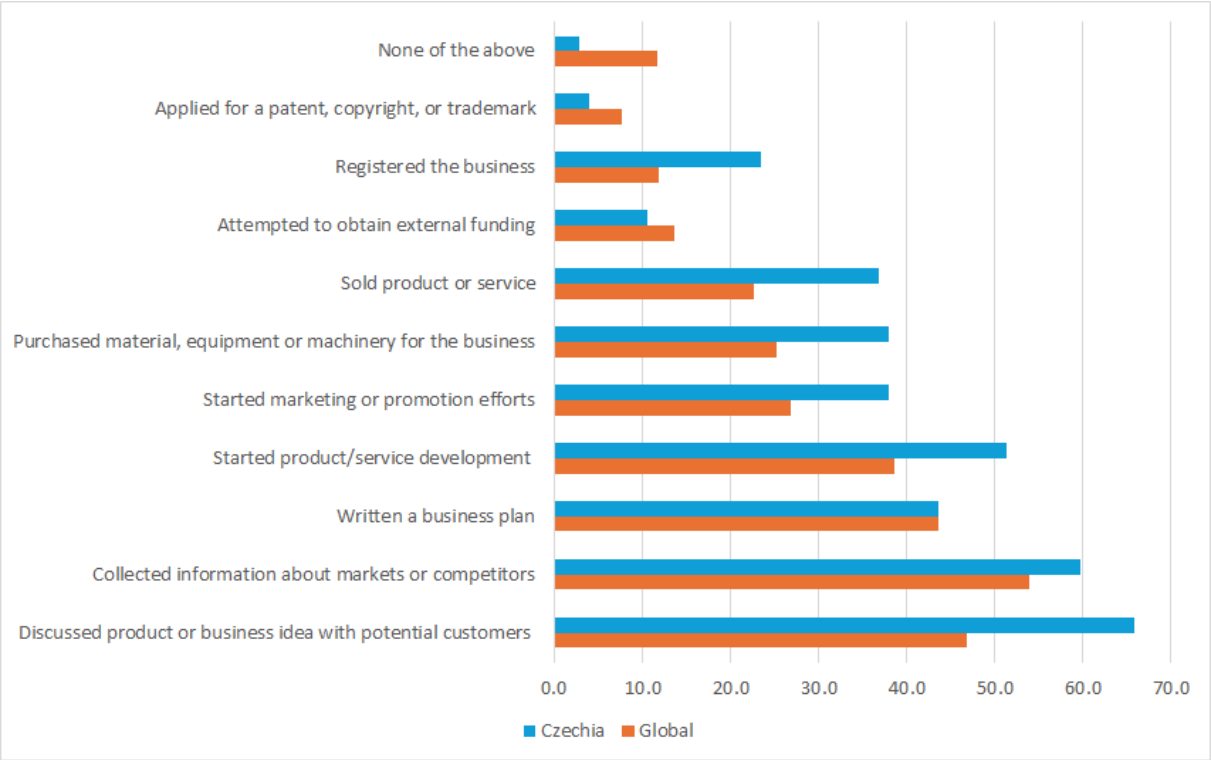
Sectoral Preferences: Czech nascent entrepreneurs closely follow the global trend of gravitating towards modern, low-barrier sectors. The Orange Economy (creative industries) and the Yellow Economy (IT, AI, and digitalisation) are the dominant targets. However, there is also a significant presence in trade and professional services, reflecting local economic traditions.

Advanced Gestation Activities: Comparison of start-up activities (Figure 13) shows that Czech students are often significantly more advanced in tangible steps than the global average. Specifically, 51.4% of Czech nascent entrepreneurs have already started product or service development (vs. 38.6% globally) and 23.5% have already registered their business (vs. 11.8% globally). Furthermore, 66% have already discussed their ideas with potential customers. These figures indicate high proactivity during the preparatory stage, even if it does not yet translate into regular sales.

The Paradox of Institutional Support: The institutional environment in the Czech Republic provides solid supportive infrastructure at universities. However, as with other advanced economies like Norway or Austria, a strong social safety net and a stable labour market paradoxically reduce the existential pressure on students, leading them to stay longer in the preparatory "nascent" phase instead of entering the risky "active" phase.

This profile confirms that while Czech students possess strong theoretical foundations and planning skills, their progress into real-life business operations is moderated by a pragmatic "wait-and-see" approach and a preference for gaining initial experience in employment

Figure 13: Activities carried out by nascent entrepreneurs (percent) - Globally and in Czechia



5.2. Nascent Entrepreneurs – Detailed data for the Czech Republic

While the previous section established the global context, this subchapter provides a granular analysis of the 192 Czech students currently in the process of starting a business. By examining their planned ownership structures, founding timelines, and perceptions of the institutional environment, we can better understand the internal dynamics of this critical segment of the student population.

So what are the dynamics of start-up and ownership structures of respondents from the Czech Republic? The transition from a nascent idea to a legally recognised entity remains a significant milestone. Data from Table 18 indicate a strong ambition to formalise these ventures during the educational period, with 69.7% of respondents planning to complete the founding process before graduation. However, a current "registration lag" is evident, as 71.4% of these nascent entrepreneurs have not yet officially registered their business

In terms of governance and control, Czech nascent entrepreneurs exhibit a strong preference for autonomy:

a) Ownership Stakes: A significant majority (77.1%) intend to be principal owners with a stake between 51% and 100%. A mere 1.4% plans minority holdings (0–49%) are envisioned by only 12.8% of respondents, while an equal 50/50 split.

Solo vs. Team Founding: Reflecting the high value placed on independence, 68.1% of students plan to start their business alone (

b) Table 19). Among those opting for co-founding, 18.6% plan for one partner, while only 4.8% anticipate a team of three or more.
c) Entrepreneurial Experience: The vast majority (93%) are first-time founders, confirming that the university environment serves as the primary incubator for initial entrepreneurial attempts.

Table 18: Completion of the founding process – Nascent Entrepreneurs of the Czech Republic

Completion of the founding process		
	Frequency	Valid Percent
During my studies	131	69.7
After my studies	44	23.4
Do not know yet	13	6.9
Total	188	100.0

Table 19: Starting a Business with Partners, Co-Founders – Nascent Entrepreneurs of the Czech Republic

Starting a Business with Partners, Co-Founders		
	Frequency	Valid Percent
No	128	68.1
With 1 co-founder	35	18.6
With 2 co-founders	16	8.5
With 3 or more co-founders	9	4.8
Total	188	100.0

5.2.1. Business Environment and Institutional Support

To evaluate how these students perceive the external conditions for their ventures, the report GUESSS utilises the Entrepreneurial Support Model (ESM) developed by Turker and Selcuk (2009). This framework measures Structural Support, assessing the perceived role of the state, financial institutions, and the overall socio-economic system.

Using a 7-point Likert scale (where 4.0 is neutral), the results for the Czech Republic reveal a generally sceptical perspective (Table 20). The following evaluation prioritises the identified factors based on their perceived impact, starting with the most significant systemic barriers to student entrepreneurship:

I. Financial Barriers – The most significant hurdle is the perceived difficulty in obtaining bank loans, which received the most negative rating of 4.57 (transformed index value of 3.43).
II. Systemic Support – Students perceive a lack of a coherent support system involving the public and private sectors (weighted average of 3.48).
III. Economic Opportunities: With a rating of 3.71, this item is closest to the neutral midpoint. Nevertheless, it suggests that students perceive the economic situation in their region as average to slightly unfavourable for new business opportunities.
IV. Legislative Framework – State regulations and laws are viewed as slightly adverse, with an initial rating of 4.19 (transformed to 3.81).

After reverse-coding the negative items to ensure a higher value indicates better support, the Overall Structural Support Index for the Czech Republic is calculated at 3.61 (Table 21).

Table 20: Institutional Support

	Question (1=strongly disagree, 7=strongly agree) n=173	**Weighted average**
Systemic Support	In the region where I study, student or entrepreneurs are encouraged by a structural system including private, public, and non-governmental organizations	3.48
Economic Opportunities	In the region where I study, … the economy provides many opportunities for student entrepreneurs	3.71
Financial Barriers	In the region where I study, taking loans from banks is quite difficult for student entrepreneurs.	4.57
Legislative Framework	In the region where I study, state laws (rules and regulations) are adverse to student entrepreneurs	4.19

1. Evaluation methodology (according to Turker & Selcuk, 2009)

All 4 items in the questionnaire are measured on a 7-point Likert scale (where 1 = strongly disagree, 4 = neutral attitude, 7 = strongly agree). Items 3 and 4 are formulated negatively (a higher value means worse conditions for students). In order to calculate the overall structural support index (where a higher value indicates better support), we need to inversely recode these two items.

The formula for inverse coding on a 7-point scale is:

$$X_{\text{new}} = 8 - X_{\text{original}}$$

2. Data calculation and transformation

Table 21 presents the recoded data. Based on the data adjustment, see Table 21, the overall index was calculated.

$$\text{Overall index} = \frac{3.48 + 3.71 + 3.43 + 3.81}{4} = \mathbf{3.61}$$

Table 21: Institutional Support – Reverse Coding

Item (Question)	**Original weighted average**	**Code adjustment**	**Result value for the index**
1. Support from the system (private, public sector, NGO)	3.48	*Direct coding*	3.48
2. Opportunities in the economy	3.71	*Direct coding*	3.71
3. Difficulty in obtaining bank loans	4.57	´8-4.57	3.43
4. Unfavorable state laws and regulations	4.19	´8-4.19	3.81
OVERALL INDEX OF STRUCTURAL SUPPORT	–	Average of items	3.61

3. Interpretation and evaluation of results

The overall average value of the structural support index is 3.61 on a seven-point scale. Given that the mean (neutral) value of the scale is 4.00, the resulting assessment indicates a slightly negative to skeptical perception of the institutional environment by students (n=173).

Detailed analysis of individual areas:

Financial barriers (Obtaining loans) with an original value of 4.57 is the worst perceived factor (students tend to agree that obtaining a loan from a bank is difficult for them). After the transformation (value 3.43), this confirms that the availability of financing is perceived as the most significant weakness of the entire system.

Support from institutions (State, NGO, private sector) with an average of 3.48, students tend to believe that there is not a sufficiently interconnected system in their region that would structurally support starting student entrepreneurs.

Economic opportunities and market, this item has a rating of 3.71. Although it is closest to the neutral middle, it still indicates that students perceive the economic situation in their region as rather average to slightly unfavorable for new business opportunities.

Legislative environment (Laws and regulations) with an original average of 4.19 shows that students perceive state rules and regulations as slightly unfavorable. After inversion (value 3.81), we see that they do not consider the legal framework to be optimal or downright supportive.

4. Research conclusion

According to the methodology of Turker & Selcuk (2009), perceived structural support has a direct impact on students' entrepreneurial intentions. The result of 3.61 indicates that the external environment in a given region does not act as a positive stimulus, but rather as a barrier. If local institutions would like to support startups among university students, they should focus primarily on facilitating access to financing (e.g. student grants or microloans) and simplifying administration (legislation).

5.2.2. Concluding Summary of Section 5.2

The detailed data for Czech nascent entrepreneurs paint a picture of high individual proactivity tempered by perceived systemic barriers. The findings show a cohort that is highly motivated to maintain individual control and autonomy, with 68.1% planning to launch their ventures as solo founders and 69.7% intending to complete the process during their studies.

However, the Structural Support Index of 3.61 indicates that the external environment is perceived more as a barrier than a catalyst. While students view economic opportunities (3.71) as nearly average, they are critical of the institutional support system (3.48) and especially access to finance (3.43). To effectively bridge the "nascent-active gap," it is recommended that regional and national policy interventions focus on simplifying administrative requirements and introducing targeted financial instruments, such as student-specific grants, to convert these high-potential latent intentions into functioning market entities.

6. Family Business Dynamics and Succession

This chapter provides an in-depth analysis of students from family business owners, who represent 25.6% of the Czech sample (see Chapter 3). By examining their upbringing, psychological involvement and succession intentions, we seek to understand the future of the "next generation" in the Czech business landscape.

6.1. Profile of family businesses in the Czech Republic

Structural characteristics: Analysis of years of establishment, company size (FTE) and sectoral distribution within the "Economy Colours". In terms of ownership and control, an assessment of the shares of parent companies was carried out.

Of the total number of 1387 respondents, 287 answered the question about the year of establishment of the company (the return rate for this question was 20.7%). After cleaning the data for obvious errors in writing (values -400, 0 and 19; a total of 6 cases), we analyzed a set of 281 valid responses (Table 22). The research sample consists mainly of mature and established companies. More than 66% of the surveyed organizations were established before 2010 and have been operating on the market for more than 16 years. **The most common year of establishment was 2000** (MODUS, 32 companies, i.e. 11.4% of the cleaned sample). The youngest represented companies were established in 2025, while the oldest has been operating since 1931. This mix ensures a robust view from the perspective of both long-standing businesses and newly established startups.

Table 22: Year of establishment of parents' businesses (at least one parent)

Category (Age of Companies)	**Year of establishment**	**Number of companies (Frequency)**	**Percentage of cleared (N=281)**
Traditional / Historical (37+ years)	before 1989	12	4.3%
Established from the 1990s (27-36 years)	1990–1999	81	28.8%
Mature Companies (17-26 years)	2000–2009	93	33.1%
Younger Companies (7-16 years)	2010–2019	67	23.8%
New Companies / Startups (up to 6 years)	2020–2025	28	10.0%
Total		281	100.0%

The question on the total number of employees converted into full-time equivalents (FTE) was answered by 292 respondents (21.1% of the total sample). The results show that the sample under study is mainly made up of very small entities. The vast majority are micro-enterprises and self-employed persons (0–9 employees), which represent 84.6% of all valid responses. The most common case is a company with 1 employee (32.2%), while a full 10.3% of respondents are completely self-employed without employees. Small enterprises (10–49 employees) are represented in 12.3% of cases (36 companies) and medium-sized enterprises (50 or more employees) form a marginal part of the sample with a share of 3.1% (9 companies). The largest organization in the sample has 230 employees (Table 23).

Table 23: Distribution of Businesses by Size (FTE)

Enterprise Size Category	Number of Employees (FTE)	Frequency (No. of Firms)	Valid Percentage (N=292)
Sole Traders / Self-Employed (Owner only)	0	30	**10.30%**
Micro-enterprises	1 – 9	217	**74.30%**
Small enterprises	10 – 49	36	**12.30%**
Medium-sized enterprises	50 – 230	9	**3.10%**
Total		292	**100.0%**

In the case of parent companies, the economic sector in which the respondents' parents' businesses mainly operate was also examined. A total of 341 valid responses were recorded. The results show that family businesses are most often represented in the category of other unspecified sectors (Other) with a share of 33.1% and in traditional industry and construction (Red Economy), which accounts for 31.4%. The information technology and digitalization sector (Yellow Economy) follows at a significant distance with a share of 9.4%. Sectors oriented towards healthcare and pharmaceuticals (White Economy – 6.2%) and creative industries (Orange Economy – 5.9%) show comparable representation. On the other hand, the fewest family businesses operate in the area of environmentally friendly sectors (Green Economy – 2.1%) and in non-renewable energy or maritime tourism (Blue and Brown Economy, 1.8% each). These results indicate that the family businesses surveyed have a strong foundation in the secondary sector (manufacturing and construction), while progressive digital services and environmentally focused economies currently constitute a minority part of the sample

Furthermore, an analysis of the **ownership share of parents** in the surveyed companies was conducted. A total of 322 respondents answered this question. The data obtained show a very strong concentration of ownership in the hands of parents. A full 80.1% of them are majority owners with a share between 51% and 100%. This result confirms that in the vast majority of cases, families have direct control over the strategic management of their companies. Minority ownership shares (0–49%) are held by parents only in 11.8% of cases and they own exactly half of the company (50%) in 8.1% of cases. The results indicate that the surveyed family companies are highly autonomous in terms of decision-making powers and independent of external co-owners, which represents a stable starting position for any future intergenerational transfer of the company.

6.2. Early involvement and external work experience

As part of the analysis of the respondents' family background, aspects of involvement in the family business, communication about entrepreneurship in the family and perception of its benefits were examined.

The results show that 39.3% of respondents from entrepreneurial families have direct work experience with the operation of a family business, which represents an important basis for their own entrepreneurial socialization.

However, communication about entrepreneurial topics during adolescence took place in families with varying intensity - most often occasionally (34.2%), while 24.6% of respondents discussed entrepreneurship often to very often. On the contrary, 41.1% of respondents stated that these topics were rarely or not discussed at home.

A very encouraging finding is the perception of the overall benefits that parents derive from entrepreneurship. The vast majority of those surveyed (52.0%) perceive these benefits rather or very positively, while only 13.7% of respondents expressed a negative perception. In the eyes of their children, parents' entrepreneurship is perceived primarily as a successful activity with positive benefits, which is a key factor influencing the formation of a positive relationship to entrepreneurship in the younger generation.

As part of a more detailed examination of the group of respondents who have direct work experience in a family business, we focused on the age of their first involvement and the total length of experience. The results show that family business affects children's lives very early. More than two-thirds of respondents (71.0%) started helping in the family business before reaching adulthood, with the most common age of first involvement being 15 years old (31.0%). A fifth of respondents (20.0%) even helped their parents as children between the ages of 12 and 14. Only 29.0% of students started working in the family business only after reaching adulthood.

In terms of the total length of experience, the respondents are divided into two dominant groups. The first half (49.5%) worked in the family business for less than 6 months in total, which indicates a model of occasional or seasonal help (e.g. in the form of summer jobs during studies). Conversely, the second significant group, representing 33.7% of respondents, has long-term work experience exceeding 12 months. These students thus have deep insight into the running of a family business and are potentially the best-prepared successors for future intergenerational transfer.

A significant finding in the context of the professional development of the young generation is their high level of involvement in the open labor market. A full 83.9% of respondents have work experience outside the family business, with most of them (60.7%) having long-term experience exceeding one year. This trend contrasts sharply with the length of experience directly in family businesses, where students participate more in the form of short-term assistance.

A key aspect is also sectoral diversification: 90.0% of students worked in an industry that is in no way related to the family business. From the perspective of succession theory and intergenerational knowledge transfer, this is a highly positive phenomenon.

Main Findings and Recommendations

The following summary provides a comprehensive overview of student entrepreneurship in the Czech Republic compared to global trends, based on the GUESSS 2025 results. The Czech Republic occupies a position typical of a mature and stable economy where entrepreneurship is perceived as a strategic choice rather than an existential necessity. The potential for future growth remains high, evidenced by a stable entrepreneurial core of 10–15% of students and the country's success in narrowing the gender gap more effectively than the global average. A comprehensive comparison of the key performance indicators for student entrepreneurship in the Czech Republic against global benchmarks is presented in Table 24. These are further visualized in the National Dashboard (see back), which was created with the support of artificial intelligence to provide an intuitive overview of the Czech entrepreneurial environment.

Table 24: Comparative Overview – Czechia vs the Global results

Metric	Czech Republic (CZ)	Global results	Relevant Chapter
Direct Intent (Founder right after study), %	10.7	15.4	2.1
Long-term Intent (Founder 5 years later), %	28.8	28.3	2.1
Active Entrepreneurs, %	3.4	6.4	2.1/4.1
Nascent Entrepreneurs, %	13.8	16.5	2.1/5.1
No Prior Work Experience, %	20.6	42.4	1.2/4.1
Individual Entrepreneurial Orientation (IEO), index 1–7	4.04	4.7	3.1/3.2.3
Gender Gap (among active entrepreneurs), % points	2.7	3.3	3.1

Note: All percentages refer to the share of respondents within the respective sample (CZ n=1,387; Global n=196,162)

The key characteristics of entrepreneurial interest in the Czech Republic can be summarized as follows.

1. The "Wait-and-See" Approach: Czech students exhibit a pronounced "employee first, entrepreneur second" career pattern. While they are less likely than their global peers to start a business immediately after graduation (10.7% vs 15.4%), their long-term intentions for a five-year horizon actually exceed the global average (28.8% vs 28.3%). This suggests that students view employment as a strategic training ground to accumulate necessary human capital and professional contacts before embarking on their own ventures.

2. Entrepreneurial Spirit: There is a significant transition barrier within the Czech ecosystem, known as the "nascent-active gap". While 13.8% of students are in the preparatory phase, only one in four successfully transitions to an active business during their studies. Despite this gap, the underlying entrepreneurial spirit remains strong; with an IEO of 4.1 and high family business exposure (25.6%), the potential for future entrepreneurship in the Czech Republic is substantial.

3. Gender Equality: The Czech Republic is performing notably better than the global average in closing the gender gap within student entrepreneurship. The gap between male and female active entrepreneurs is only 2.7% in favour of men, which is narrower than the global average gap of 3.3%.

4. Field of Entrepreneurship: Growing student interest is concentrated in modern, low-barrier sectors. The "Yellow Economy" (IT, AI, and digitalisation) and the "Orange Economy" (creative industries) are the dominant targets for student-led start-ups, offering high potential for innovation without requiring massive initial capital.

Strategic recommendations are presented from both the university and student perspectives.

Universities should:

- ✓ Strengthen the "University Environment" score (currently around 4) by providing more practical incubation programmes.
- ✓ Activating incubators: Make university advisory centres and incubators more visible across all faculties, not just in economic fields
- ✓ Practical "Learn by Doing": Instead of theory, introduce courses where students start a "dirty" company in the safe environment of the school to overcome the fear of failure
- ✓ Interdisciplinary networking: Support meetings between students in technical/artistic fields (ideas) and students in economics (business skills)
- ✓ Performance Coaching: Given the lower self-assessment of performance (4.35), universities should provide more mentorship to help active student entrepreneurs scale their businesses.
- ✓ Strategic Planning: Encourage nascent entrepreneurs to move from the "idea" phase to the "written plan" phase, as less than half globally reach this milestone.

Students and (potential) entrepreneurs should:

- ✓ Participate in events like “FuckUp Nights” that help destigmatise failure and show it as a natural part of learning,
- ✓ Be less hard on yourself: Czech student entrepreneurs evaluate their companies’ performance more critically than their peers around the world,
- ✓ Use mentoring and coaching to gain a more objective view of your progress and scale your business better.

Institutional background in the Czech Republic

In summary, the institutional background in the Czech Republic exists. Still, its real impact is limited by students' low confidence in the technical aspects of business and the attractiveness of career paths. A helpful trigger could be the upcoming "start-up law," which is one of the most anticipated legislative steps for the Czech innovation economy. Its main goal is to create a predictable environment for young, fast-growing technology companies and help the Czech Republic catch up with neighbouring EU countries. The law consists of five main pillars:

- ✓ Official definition of start-up: This concept did not exist in Czech law until now. The law will introduce clear "hard" criteria (company age, turnover, number of employees) and "soft" criteria (innovation and scalability). This will exclude traditional crafts from support and focus exclusively on the technology sector.

- ✓ Employee Stock Ownership Plan (ESOP) reform: A key change for motivating talent. The moment of taxation of employee shares is postponed – the employee will not pay tax immediately upon obtaining the option, but only when he actually sells the share (e.g., upon an exit).

- ✓ Tax incentives for angel investors (Business Angels): Similar to the British system, private investors can deduct part of the money invested in a start-up from their income tax base, intended to attract more local capital to the sector.
- ✓ Reduction of bureaucracy and relief: Consideration is being given to reducing the administrative burden (e.g., less reporting in the first years, the possibility of making changes to the commercial register without a notary, based only on a sworn statement), as well as to more flexible forms of employment relations without the risk.
- ✓ Start-up visa: An accelerated and simplified process for obtaining residence for foreign founders and top experts (e.g. developers), which the Czech market urgently needs.

Czech students generally show a high level of caution and fear of failure. Willingness to take risks in the Czech Republic is rated at only 3.49 out of 7, which is one of the lowest scores and represents a major psychological barrier to starting a business. For the vast majority of students in the Czech Republic, entrepreneurship is an "academic blank slate", as 76.1% of them have never attended any course focused on this area. This lack of practical skills (taxes, administration, management) reduces their confidence in starting their own project. Also, the stable labour market in the Czech Republic and social security lead the students to prefer working in corporations or institutions, which they perceive as a safer alternative to the uncertainty of entrepreneurship.

However, to transform latent intentions into active businesses, the study recommends that Czech universities shift from theoretical support to practical "Learn by Doing" programmes. Bridging the "nascent-active gap" will require better visibility of incubators across all faculties and targeted institutional support to lower the perceived financial and administrative barriers.

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National Dashboard: Student Entrepreneurship in Czechia 2025

THE "WAIT-AND-SEE" APPROACH: STRATEGIC POSTPONEMENT

Immediate Intent (After Studies) — **10.7%**

Employee first, entrepreneur second

Long-term Intent (5 Years Later) — **28.8%**

Ambitions exceed global average

KEY FINDING: Strategic Postponement. While immediate intent is low, long-term ambitions are strong.

THE "NASCENT-ACTIVE" GAP: THE PARTICIPATION CHALLENGE

Nascent Entrepreneurs (Planning)

13.8%

Nearly 14% in preparatory phase

REGISTRATION LAG:

71.4%

of nascent entrepreneurs have not yet officially registered. Confirms cautious, preparatory nature.

Active Entrepreneurs (Running)

3.4%

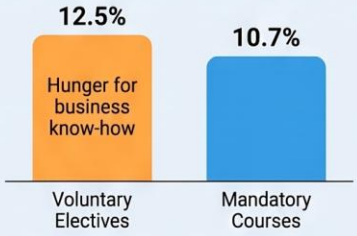
Only 1 in 4 successfully transitions

THE EDUCATION DEFICIT: ACADEMIC "BLANK SLATE"

76.1% OF STUDENTS HAVE NEVER ATTENDED AN ENTREPRENEURSHIP COURSE.

Massive absence of formal training.

ORGANIC INTEREST vs. MANDATORY



Enrolment in electives exceeds mandatory, indicating underserved demand.

FUTURE SECTORS: THE "COLOURED" ECONOMY

THE YELLOW ECONOMY (IT/Digitalisation)

Dominant for Active Entrepreneurs (31.1%). Low barriers, high innovation potential.

THE ORANGE ECONOMY (Creative Industries)

Dominant for Nascent Entrepreneurs (26.2%). Attracts highest number in planning phase.

CZECHIA vs GLOBAL BENCHMARKING

Metric	Czech Republic (CZ)	Global Results
Direct Intent (Immediately)	**10.7%**	15.4%
Long-term Intent (5 years)	**28.8%**	28.3%
Active Entrepreneurs	**3.4%**	6.4%
Nascent Entrepreneurs	**13.8%**	16.5%
No Prior Work Experience	**20.6%**	42.4%
Gender Gap (Active)	**2.7%**	3.3%

Czechia is performing notably better, 2.7% vs 3.3% global. CZ performs notably better.

INDIVIDUAL ENTREPRENEURIAL ORIENTATION (IEO): CZ Index 4.04 vs Global 4.70. Lower risk-taking (3.49) and proactivity.

NotebookLM